battle scars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32279305.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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by shchi

Summary

On a school trip, Catra is bitten by a radioactive spider. With the crime in New York so high, they decide to help out by becoming the vigilante known as Spider-Man. Yet a unique hero brings unique villains over the years - ones that may hurt Catra's girlfriend, Adora.

Notes

this will be updated weekly as it as already written! well, all i have left to do is the final chapter! i hope you enjoy!
my tumblr is *ochen* if you would like to talk/ask questions, it is also linked on my profile for ease of access!

part one: origin

There's one thing that Catra absolutely hates in this world, above all else, and that's *coffee*. They hate the smell, how bitter it is, the way it lingers in the air, the fact that some people are so weak they are actually addicted to it, seven or more cups a day. How on Earth do they do that? They can't even bring themself to fathom that one out. It makes the annoying people more annoying due to their jitters, so virtually anyone Catra encounters, that would seem. Don't even get them started on the names, pulled out of someone's ass, making no sense whatsoever, yet it makes it onto the board. The price for an espresso is unreasonable. In fact, an espresso in itself was stupid, just have a shot of vodka from the comfort of your own home instead. What is the point in queuing up for *ages* , only to buy 50ml of coffee that will go cold by the time you manage to get out the shop.

So, why are they in a coffee shop? Because of yesterday. Because of yesterday, the brunet fully set on going to a coffee shop -- it gets worse -- actually *drink* some. The thought of it makes the student physically sick. Yesterday, a friend had dragged them along so he could get a quick coffee before work, and the woman who served them genuinely took Catra's breath away. It was bad. The woman behind the counter was none other than Adora, a classmate who Catra had a *massive* crush on. It just so happened they lived next door to each other, but both of them had jobs on the weekend, and they saw each other at school five days a week anyway. They see enough of each other, but Catra always fumbles over words when it comes to just thinking about asking Adora when her next day off was, hopefully they would have the same day off, so they could spend the day together. Spending time together, voluntarily, out of school... that was a dream. If it ever happened, it would be a dream come true for Catra, but they were too nervous and Adora probably liked one of the boys anyway. She was always talking about one in particular, and as expected, it made Catra hurt inside. Perhaps he was making

moves or something that they couldn't muster up the courage to do. Well, they couldn't even muster up the courage to speak, so anything more than that was out of the picture for them. Still, it made them jealous.

Their weekend job was as mechanic, and they work with a close friend, Will. He had a day off, so it was just Catra in the café. Actually, when they walked in, it really seemed like it was just them.

And Adora.

Catra's heart leaps into their throat. It's thumping erratically, the only thing they can hear, as they walk up to the counter. Catra is only five foot, give or take, and Adora is almost six foot, towering over them. They fight back a blush when they think about that.

"Catra," she greets. "What can I get you?" she smiles, and Catra tries not to show their panic.

"J-Just a black coffee," they stammer out.

"That's two bucks," she holds out her hand as Catra places the money, fingertips touching her palm almost sends an electrical shock through their body, and in any case, it's definitely an overloaded circuit. Adora places the money in the till as she grabs a takeaway cup. "So, are you excited for Monday?" she tries to

make conversation, but Catra just stares. "You know, the trip to the genetics lab?"

"Oh. Yeah, I am."

"I was hoping you'd go. I've noticed that science always puts a smile on your face, but it's always so hard."

"So do you," Catra blurts out before they have time to process. Oh, God, what have they done?

Adora laughs a little, "You're too sweet." She places the cup of coffee on the counter. "How long do you have until you have to be at work?"

"Twenty minutes."

"Want to talk for a while?"

Catra doesn't have time to give an answer, as Adora automatically assumes it's a 'yes' and walks around to the other side of the counter and they sit at a table. Adora knows the garage where Catra works is only a five minute walk away, so they can't exactly decline because it's rude, but also, they have no idea what to say, they will make a fool of themself for sure. On the other hand, it's their best chance to talk with Adora, so they decide to go to hell

with it, and make the best of the situation. They're so far gone with infatuation; Adora is *perfect* .

Catra, after adding six packets of sugar to the coffee, takes a sip. They force themself to swallow, and it amuses Adora, who comments that the only people who add an absurd amount of sugar to tea or coffee, are the people who don't like it very much. The brunet blushes, quietly saying that she's right about it.

"Why did you buy one then?"

"I... just wanted to talk to you," they can barely hear the sound of their own voice when they speak now.

Adora giggles, and Catra only blushes more. "We're next door neighbours! You could talk to me anytime, and you have my number. What's up, then?"

"Nothing, I'm fine."

"You're not. I've known you for years, Catra. Since we were ten years old, so I know when something is bugging you."

Catra can't think of anything to say, so Adora tells them they can always text her, and she will listen and help in any way she can,

and then she changes the subject to make it easier since she can tell her friend is not comfortable.

Unfortunately, time flies. They speak about school, their parents, what they will do after they finish school -- which is only three weeks away. Exams are swamping the entire timetable, but their teacher wanted to give them a day off, a stress free day, so a trip to a genetics lab it is. They didn't have any exams on Monday anyway, so it worked out.

After saying goodbye, they both go back to work. Catra takes their denim jacket off and pulls their grey mechanic's overalls over their clothes to protect them from oil and dirt. It's tiresome, a good workout, and upper body strength is needed, but they love their job. So much. It's good pay, too, and they are very good at what they do. It was supposed to be a short stint, but after a raise and realising they were good at fixing up cars, they stayed. Their father used to work as a mechanic, teaching his child from a young age, mostly because he believed they wouldn't make it in science, and wanted them to have something to fall back on if it failed, which he believed it would. For that, Catra was determined to prove him wrong. His beliefs were strong. Catra had hidden the fact they like girls, and the fact they are non-binary from him because they know how he would react. He would react badly, saying it's stupid and wrong, that they're just going along with the crowd to fit in at school. That's not the case at all, in fact, Catra hasn't told anyone about it. Maybe the fact they like girls is more obvious than the non-binary part -- piercings, short and shaggy hair, muscular arms that would make any lesbian swoon. All they need now is a girlfriend to add to the collection of things they're too scared to tell anyone about.

Catra ends up seeing Adora leave the coffee shop, her shift over, and they greet her.

"Fancy seeing you again. You don't want another coffee, do you?" she jokes, and Catra chuckles along with her.

"Nope," they confirm, and it feels nice to be more calm around her -- able to converse and joke. There's a breeze, and it makes the blonde shiver. She's wearing a short sleeved t-shirt, so Catra offers their jacket. She smiles and thanks them as they take it off and hand it over.

Their conversations come and go. Sometimes it's nice just to walk in silence, just focus on the company rather than thinking of something to talk about.

"Are you ok?" Adora asks. "Not cold?" she steals a glance at Catra's toned arms. Catra notices.

"We should do this more often." They have no idea where this confidence is from, but they're loving it.

"We really should," she agrees as they turn into their street, and she takes off Catra's jacket. "Thank you, by the way. Kept me warm."

"No problem," they take their jacket and lay it over their forearm.

"Night, Catra."

"Night, Adora."

They each enter their houses and close their doors after that, smiling to themselves.

Catra notices that their jacket smells of Adora's perfume, and they smile more before heading up to the kitchen to see what they can put together for dinner.

It's Monday morning. Catra has toast for breakfast before brushing their teeth. They're wearing black jeans, a plain black t-shirt, and their denim jacket again, completed with white trainers, picking up their glasses on the way out. They wear contacts on weekends as it's easier to work that way. Their eyesight isn't that bad, it's mainly reading that is the problem. They sent Adora a text, and she offers to give them a lift to school because her brother, Bow, doesn't have to use the car today, since he is off work due to being sick. Adora was adopted by his family from a young age. The brunet agrees, still nervous, but slightly less than yesterday morning. They climb in the passenger side and click the seatbelt in while Adora fiddles with finding a radio station, which plays quietly in the background in case Catra wants to talk. She hopes they are alright, they used to so close until a few years

ago. They were 15 when Catra became distant, and she couldn't figure out why that was, but she never asked out of politeness. She wants them to know that they can trust her. She misses them, but she won't make them uncomfortable by forcing them to be friends again; she would just like a reason why, that's all.

They arrive at school and get onto the bus that will take them to the laboratory. There's already a few people from their class on it. There's around 30 students in total, a class too big for Catra's nerves because more people might see her sneak glances at Adora in class that way. They sit in two seats at the very back of the bus, talking while they wait. More people arrive, and the teacher checks everyone is here by calling out their names. After that, they're off.

The journey was long, and both Catra and Adora fell asleep, and Adora's head on Catra's shoulder. Catra wakes up when the bus stops outside the laboratory, and they gently nudge the brunette awake. She yawns, stretching her arms as she comes to her senses, and they make their way off the bus together. They keep up with the rest of the class as they're shown around the lab, their main feature being about genetically modified spiders. Neither Catra or Adora are that keen on spiders, but Catra is probably more comfortable than her, as Adora doesn't even want to look, and if she does, it's between her fingers as her hands cover her eyes. There's probably a dozen or so, even some baby spiders.

While Catra is looking, they gently tap the glass of a tank and then smiles as one of spiders seems to lift up one of it's legs as if it was waving. They chuckle, giving a small wave back before turning their attention to the scientist who was talking.

"Ow," they mutter under their breath as something pinches the back of their hand. It felt like a bite, they turn their hand over and look, there's a two tiny little dots bleeding, and when they look, there's a dead spider by their feet. They wipe their hand on their jeans and think of it as nothing, continuing the rest of the tour while comforting Adora who becomes more terrified as they go along.

In total, they spent three hours at the genetics laboratory, and they're given the rest of the day off. Adora pulls up in her drive way. "Hey, you don't look so good," she says as she realises Catra is quite pale.

"Maybe I'm coming down with something. I can't really see," they say as they gesture to their glasses. They take them off, and it's no better, but they also feel light headed now.

Adora's quick to catch Catra when they nearly fall down as Adora lets go of their arm to unlock their front door. "You're going straight to bed, I'll bring you a glass of water," she says as she kicks the door shut and escorts Catra to their room. After, she goes to the kitchen and fills a glass with water for Catra before taking some pain killers out her backpack, putting them into a shot glass and placing both glasses onto the bed side table, but by that point, Catra is fast asleep. Just to be on the safe side, Adora does check for a pulse, and then she leaves.

Catra wakes up, and grabs their glasses so they can read the couple of text messages displayed on their phone's lockscreen. It's blurry, so they take their glasses off, only to discover that they can read perfectly without them. There's two texts from Adora. The first saying that she hopes they feel better, and to take the pain killers if needed, and the second saying their exam this morning has been cancelled, so not to worry about that either.

They take the pain killers, before thinking that they better watch out for the shot glass because it's about to fall. Before they even have time to process that thought, they automatically catch the glass the moment it slips off the edge of the bed side table. Catra stares at the glass in their hand, shocked and confused. They place the glass down and turn over to see the back of their hand; the bite marks are scabbed, and also, the glass is still being held. Damn, that'll get annoying if they can't figure out how to unstick the glass from their person. They have a ridiculous thought next about the spider bite doing something to their body, but in hindsight, it may just link together. They calm down, taking a few deep breaths and then their hand lets go of the shot glass, but that's only a solution to a very minor problem right now. It didn't add up to anything else, and they certainly can't tell anyone about this. Reason number one being that it's literally unbelievable.

That's the thing with Catra, most of the people in their life probably won't believe what they say, but this is different, because Catra can hardly believe it themself, but it gives them an idea, that they can use their powers for good. The crime is awfully high in New York. They could train, get used to it, create a suit to conceal their identity, and maybe most importantly, they could somehow create their own webs to travel faster. It's possible. Very possible, but unlike their very obvious crush on their neighbour, this is a secret that they really can't let loose. *Really*.

becoming

It's been four days, exams for the week are over, but Catra knew they would ace them anyway, so they spent their time working on creating a web fluid, that on contact with air, will form webbing that will carry them from skyscraper to skyscraper. The thing about New York was that all the buildings are *so* high. As a starting point, the 17 year old went into an alley to see if they could stick to walls. They ended up climbing all the way up, finding out they could stand up on a wall, and also run up them. Only their fingertips and the balls of their feet were needed, and they discovered that they could quite easily just have one half attached to the wall, and they wouldn't fall or slip. Wearing all black wasn't quite enough for Catra, they needed something distant that would conceal their identity, while being a symbol of hope for the city that could easily be recognised. In comes the idea for the suit; mostly red with some blue on the sleeves and legs, and was all one piece except for the mask. They had begun with the feet, which were soles of shoes, heavy grip on the bottom, and red fabric attached, sewn with black thread, which soon became like a spider web pattern.

Sewing was a secret skill of theirs from the time they took a textiles class for a few months after school to pass the time, but they never expected it to be needed to this extreme. They had purchased the materials for quite cheap, but finding good quality lenses was the biggest issue. They also had to make sure the fabric was breathable, or else they considered sticking two small needle pricks where their nose would be just to be sure. The mask did muffle their voice, but they already decided on putting on a deeper voice anyway. After all, they were going to be Spider-*Man* , not Spider-Secretly-Non-Binary-Teenager. They had thought about going by *the Spider*, but it didn't sound like it was all there, like it needed something extra. They didn't mind going by Spider-Man, they had a masculine outline anyway, and they were far more comfortable with that than *Spider-Woman.* They could

barely pass as a woman anyway, practically zero bust, and they were so happy they had turned out like that.

Apart from the suit and deciding what to be called, the web fluid was coming along. Digging out their textbooks and deciding on the best components, sneaking into the science labs after the exams to collect the chemicals, staying up at night to craft prototypes. Naturally, a spider's webbing is strong, having a tensile strength of 1.8 gigapascals (one gigapascal is one billion pascals), meaning it can withstand or pull a weight of up to 1.8 gigapascals without breaking -- *impressive.* Pascals is a unit of pressure, one Newton per square metre, and Catra's top two subjects just happen to be chemistry and physics, so making artificial webbing was a dream come true, and such a project. Carbon nanotubes popped up in their mind, and they flicked to the textbook page. They seemed to be the best option as the maximum tension was 1.98 x 105 Newtons. A brand new notebook -- four days old -- was now filled by messily laid out calculations and brainstorms, corrections, solutions and revelations.

Catra sighs as they clear their room, free of the last web test. If they got this one correct, the webs should disintegrate an hour after exposure to air. The fluid will be kept in thin, short cylinders, air tight, attached to the wrists of the suit. A thin, long strand ran from the in-use cylinder to the palm of their hand, where their middle and ring finger would trigger the release of the webbing on contact with the sensor. There would be space to have four vials, two each side of the one in use. In the trials so far, test one wouldn't even solidify upon release (so it looked rather... questionable, to say the least), test two failed to stick to anything, while test three would disintegrate while still travelling to the wall, so it didn't stick unless Catra was close enough. Taking the disintegration agent out of it all together, test four actually stuck, and Catra thought about leaving it at that, but it would only leave

someone else to clear up the webs in their place. An hour would give enough time for the police to show up, and they would plan to call them with the location of the crime after they had dealt with, and restrained the one behind it using the web shooters.

This is test five, and Catra has high hopes for it. They fire a strand of webbing to the wall, when they release their fingers from the sensor, it cuts off the cylinder from releasing any more. It sticks, and they set the timer, and return work on their suit.

An hour later, the web starts to disintegrate and the suit is finally complete. Now the next phase can begin: the leap of faith.

By luck, Catra's father was always at work, so after their shift today, they could spend as much time outside their room as they wanted. After a rather drastic career change, he was a high ranking police officer, a very busy man. When he was home, he didn't pay much attention to his only child. In this scenario, it was quite good to have a neglectful father. They slip into their suit, a good fit -- a good job if they could say that themself. Securing the web-shooters on either wrist, they go out the back door, continuing to the fence at the end of the garden and jumping over it. Not far from where they live are some old train tracks, which mean there will be a bridge that they can swing under because they didn't want to start by jumping off a skyscraper and colliding with the road when the web shooters fail -- better to start smaller when it came to these things.

Climbing the wall, they jump over to the other side, onto the train tracks. The wall is quite tall, but not tall enough to practice swinging. They decide to test their stamina instead, running along the track, five minutes and they are just a few hundred yards

from the tall bridge, so they put their middle and ring finger to the sensor, then release, to trigger a strand of web an appropriate length. It connects to the bridge, they hold the other end in their hand and it pulls them along and off the ground. With their other hand, they fire another web, letting go of the old one and holding the new one, and momentum and gravity does the rest as they repeat the process, getting the hang of it quickly.

Out from under the bridge, they swing back over the wall, now in an area with tall apartment buildings. After swinging from building to building, they swing towards a building, shooting two strands of web directly above and pulling themself up like it was a slingshot. Laughing to themself, they run across the rooftop before jumping off the edge. They fire a web at the last minute, the adrenaline rush leaving them wanting more, so they do it again. Then again. They go back to making their way through the city, and it's around eight o'clock in the evening -- the night is just beginning, and the criminals are too.

Catra drops down directly behind a thug who they thought they would give a bit more time to see if he could even get the door open of the vehicle he was trying to steal, but he didn't, so he was now stuck to the car before he even knew it. There's a cop approaching, so the new hero is quick to leave the scene, not before sticking a scribbled note on the not so successful car thief.

On the next street, they can see three men -- the ones that scream 'trouble', and they land on the side of a building just to wait until they make a move. It's not as long a wait as the car thief, they swoop down and subdue the attackers with ease, and it makes them realise how much stronger they are now. They had been in fights before, and they weren't using their full strength now, but they were definitely stronger because of how quick the

three went down. They'd have to test that later, but for now, they are quick to fire webs at the men, sticking them to the wall. They turn to the woman who the three thugs were a split second away from attacking, the only thing one of them got to say was: *"Hey, give us your purse!"* before Catra intervened. It was only after Catra had dealt with the men that they realise who it was that they have saved: *Adora.* The Adora who made their heart skip a beat, make them stutter and blush by gracing their presence with her divine beauty. *Their* Adora. Catra is thankful for the mask for concealing their ever-growing blush.

"Thank you!" the blonde smiles as their saviour turns around to face them.

"Just doing my part," they say in a voice deeper than their own. Moving to the side, they place the tips of their fingers on the wall of the building.

"Wait, who are you?"

"Your friendly neighbourhood Spider-Man," was all they say before they start to climb the wall before repeating the slingshot manoeuvre from earlier -- it was quickly becoming one of their favourite moves, not that they had many yet. They continue to swing through the city, getting much needed practice, adding five more prevented crimes to their total, and no doubt they will be the talk of the city in the morning. It's the start of something great.

"Fuck!" Catra exclaims as they jump out of bed at the sight of the time. Grabbing their phone, they see the messages from their boss, Adora telling them about how Spider-Man saved her last night, and instead of rushing to get ready for work, they type in their alter-ego's name into the search engine to see what people are saying.

New York City's Hero: Spider-Man

From last night, people have been going crazy for this city's defender. He goes by the name Spider-Man, and witnesses say he wears a distinctive red and blue suit, easily spotted when he travels using some sort of web going from building to building. People say he also has the ability to climb up walls, even run up them. A vigilante, Spider-Man is one step ahead of the police. He leaves criminals restrained by the use of webs, and lets the police do the rest. However, police and the public are divided, with the public praising Spidey for stopping crimes, and the police saying that they are more than capable, and do not need his help. Still, everyone needs help now and then, and he's doing no harm. Some commenters have even said that he's better than the police, so, what are your thoughts?

Clicking off the article, the second result caught their eye. The Daily Bugle's article headline was: *Spider-Man: Threat or Menace?* There was no time to read it now, they were missing work. They had showered late last night when they finally got home, so Catra simply pulled on the first pair of jeans and t-shirt they could find, no socks on their feet as they pulled their trainers on, leaving the house quickly after. As they walk, they text their employer, saying they'd be in within ten minutes, and that they were feeling sick

due to what they assumed to be food poisoning. The mechanic opens their neighbour's text next, a lengthy message at that. Chuckling they respond with: *'Spider-Man sounds like a charmer then. Try not to fall too hard for him!'*

Fuck. Wait, this is a good thing right? That Adora is seemingly still on that high from being saved by a mysterious stranger. Well, maybe it would be, if Adora hadn't then replied to the message, asking why Catra was one: late for work, two: came back home so late last night, three: never opened their curtains, and also, that they might want to clean their room due to the cobwebs, and Catra swears again. She was onto them, and Catra had to somehow deflate her suspicions before it all piled up.

'Late night yesterday, massive hangover,' they hit send before putting their phone in their pocket to quicken their pace. They get to work, pulling on their mechanic's overalls before getting to work. "People really need to take more notice in what their car is warning them about," they mutter as they sit in the driver's seat of a customer's car that they brought in because a warning light was blinking, and they couldn't find what it meant in the book. Catra sighs, deducing it as the brake pads on the way out.

Raising the car on the jack and jack stands, they're starting to remove the wheel when their co-worker starts a conversation. *Wrong time, Will,* they think, but give him a smile anyway.

"Did you hear about Spider-Man?"

"New hero, right? Yeah, well, the police don't do shit, anyway. It's good he's around."

"Really?"

Catra assumes Will isn't a fan, but stays silent for a few seconds as they take the wheel off the car. "Why do you ask?"

"Your father is a cop, right? He can't be happy."

"Can't say we've spoken about it. Hardly see him. He's on night shifts, so he's asleep during the day."

"I don't like him."

"My dad?" they smirk slightly.

"No, this Spider-Man guy. Someone should do something -- he's probably dangerous."

"He's stopped ten crimes already, first night too."

"Why do you defend him so much? I thought you like girls."

"What's with you? All I'm saying is I think he's a good person helping others," Catra glances at him, and their sixth sense (that they have decided to call 'Spider-Sense' or the article nicknaming the hero as Spidey makes them want to refer to it as 'Spidey-Sense') tells them something is wrong here. They have come to realise that the stronger the tingling sensation in their head is, the closer or greater the danger is. It's faint right now, they decide to ignore it, but keep it in mind as it wouldn't warn them for no reason. One more glance at their co-worker, they notice he is rubbing his right forearm as if it aches or something, and the tingling sensation is slightly stronger now. Funnily enough, it never goes off around Adora.

Ignore it, it's nothing, you're still getting used to everything, are the words they keep telling themself, and they focus on the task at hand. Brake pads, although it's a pain to remove the wheel, are an easy job to fix, so it doesn't take long once they're in.

"Hey, I was told my car would be finished in an hour." Catra recognises that voice as they sit behind the reception desk, waiting for the next customer to either drop off or collect their car, and they look up to see Adora.

"Brake pads?"

"Yep, that's the one."

Catra gets the keys while Adora enters her pin of her card on the chip and pin machine. "Car's out front," they say as they handed over the keys.

"Thanks, Catra. Shall I give you a coupon for a free cup of coffee in return?"

Catra laughs, "Nah, it's alright."

Adora laughs with them, saying if there's anything she can do, to let her know since she owns them one now.

"I'll keep that in mind," they say in a playful tone before Adora nods and leaves.

Before long, it's the end of the working day, and Will leaves a few minutes before Catra does, and for once, they don't mind. They have enough on their plate at the moment as it is, and if Adora is already suspicious, they couldn't risk talking more to Will about Spider-Man. Leading a double life is harder than Catra thought it would be, coupled with school ending in a few weeks, they need to focus on several things at once: getting the grades they need, being a good employee, and not getting in over their head while being Spider-Man at night -- and all while keeping each part separate. Oh, there was one more thing, to not let Adora in on their secret. Their rooms were opposite each other, Catra is often up late at night now, curtains drawn and the light on, so it means that Adora is able to see a silhouette -- which is bad for too many reasons. If she figures out Catra is Spider-Man, they were scared for what it would mean for their friendship, and a lot of questions

about why it wasn't Spider-Woman saving the people of New York. They haven't told Adora that they were non-binary -- no one at all knows apart from Catra. They felt safer that way, less to be judged by if no one knew. Well, they knew for a fact that Adora would support them no matter what. They also knew that Adora would worry about them if she knew their secret identity -- she has always worried about Catra because they have a lot of troubles, and they won't let anyone inside their head.

Catra makes it back home, walking past Adora's house to see the car in the drive-way. Her family will probably be having dinner at this hour, and Adora always asks Catra to join them because she knows they eat poorly and alone due to their father starting work at this hour as well. Catra doesn't want to intrude, so they don't accept. They're too stubborn for their own good, and it's a fact that they both know all too well.

Closing the front door with their foot, they lock it and leave their keys in there as they take out their phone to order a pizza. They're tired from last night and from work today -- both physically demanding, but for some reason, they are the one the spider had chosen to bite, to be gifted with powers that they didn't know the extent of, but they did know how to put them to good use. No one else has this ability, or they would have been famous by now. They're special -- unique, and the hot new topic of New York, never mind the rest of the country -- or world. The downside to these abilities would be that people will want to try and clone them, and if not that, to have Spider-Man squashed like a bug due to the 'threat' he apparently possesses.

With the suit on, Catra is on the roof of the apartment black where they had ordered the pizza to. The delivery man finally appeared through the door, and they hand him the money.

Instead of taking it, he has a bit of a moment before excitedly asking for their autograph. For a moment, they are stunned, but they sign the piece of paper he is holding out. He's so grateful that it makes Catra smile behind the mask, and they tell him to have a good day. Or, evening rather. After he leaves, they sit on the edge of the roof, legs dangling down, and open up the pizza. They pull their mask up, exposing their mouth and it sits on their nose as they eat their dinner. With this time, they take a moment to reflect on what this new identity will mean in the future.

Spider-Man's purpose is clear, protect the vulnerable -- so, pretty much everyone in the city, but also, to take the time to make someone's day, be it an autograph or taking a selfie with them. Not everyone would be a fan of him, but it would be boring if everyone was. Yet, the ones who didn't, the ones who would take that pure hatred to the extreme, they were the ones he would have to look out for. If someone hated him enough to put people in danger, to terrorise this city, because they knew he would show up, he would be sure to defeat them and protect the civilians.

People have a right to fear the unknown. They have a right to be scared of new technology, but what they shouldn't do is actively try and counter it with their own technology, because Catra -- or rather, Spider-Man, would soon learn that people who chose to become a mutate, it always ended up bad, unlike becoming one purely by the circumstances on that day.

truth

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's been two weeks since Spider-Man appeared, and it meant two weeks of avoiding Adora's questions of why Catra has so many bruises or scabs. Their father noticed when they were both awake and at home at the same time. He told them to be careful, not to end up like their mother. He used to be a good father, until his wife died, leaving him and a six year old Catra behind. It was around that time he quit his job as mechanic to become a police officer, in hopes of finding the truth surrounding his wife's demise, but 11 years later, he was still in the same place regarding any insight into her death. A child, Catra didn't quite understand what happened, all they knew was their father would shout for no reason. He was never... violent, but there were times where Catra really believed that he would, and they would cower in fear and pray the anger would pass before it boiled over and burnt them.

Every time their mother was mentioned, always the same feeling in the pit of their stomach. She died in a plane crash. She worked as a research agent for the government, working with some doctor about regeneration, and how they could potentially regenerate human cells. Catra was finding this out now, when they found a box with their mother's name on in the attic when they were looking for their small, old robot spider toy. As luck would have it, it was already red.

It can crawl by Catra controlling it by a little control pad, and it made them think what if they can place a small camera inside, make a hole in one of the eyes for it to be placed, and connect the camera feed to the control pad. It's a challenge, but it could

be helpful in the future, be their eyes and ears when physically being around would alert the enemy. It's also a challenge because the things in life that could allow some heavy handedness, like squeezing toothpaste and trying to get the hot tap to turn on, well, the tap had fully broken when Catra yanked it, unaware of their on strength, and the the entire content of the toothpaste tube ended up on the mirror. Also, last week, they had caught a car like it was nothing when a getaway driver had crashed into it and sent it flying. So, yeah, their strength is definitely the one they have the most trouble trying to control, so they hold back in fights. They assume they can easily lift ten tonnes. Another example, they had slammed a door in anger, and the door handle came off in their hand, the door came off it's hinges, and it split down the middle.

Anyway, the spider-bot, it looks cute, Catra is sat on their bed as they fiddle around with mechanism, eventually managing to place the camera inside, the lense of it looking through the middle eye piece. It takes longer than expected, but eventually, they manage to relay the camera feed to the control pad, and they test it by sending the robot out their room. Another idea comes into their mind, if they could make it fly and shoot at multiple enemies, because they were bound to fight multiple people all at once sooner or later. There has been a few close calls already, some by opponents getting lucky, and some by Catra's own foolishness. They seem to heal quicker, but one day, it won't be quick enough, and the people of New York will by the price, or worse, one of Catra's loved ones.

Catra picks up their phone after it buzzes, and reads Adora's message. She's asked them so many times to come round for dinner, have some actual food instead of takeaway after takeaway, or some pasta they found in the back of the cupboard with some cheese because they couldn't cook, or rather, Adora suspected that they were too *busy* to cook something decent for themself.

They text back, agreeing to the evening. Throwing their phone carelessly on the bed, they continue playing with the new spider-bot. Smiling, they spend far too much time, too happy, about this. It's still a success, just one only they can relate to. Another secret.

With some free time after tearing themself away from their new gadget, they decide to go around town the a few hours before they have to be at Adora's, to see if anything pops up.

Catra rings the doorbell, and it opens a few seconds later. "You made it!" Adora sounds happy, but Catra can't work out if she's happy to see them or if she's happy that Catra is on time. "Can I talk to you?" she asks, stepping forward to shut the door so they're both outside.

Catra looks at Adora, "What's up?"

"I saw something -- some *one* -- climb into your room last night."

Catra swallows.

"Your room is on the second floor, Catra. And the cobwebs, and you're smart enough to know that if the curtains are closed, I can still see the silhouette. I want you to know you can trust me. I can keep a secret better than you can."

"Fine," they sigh. "You figured me out. I'm Spider-Man," they throw their arms in the air in defeat, comically. They smile a little and with a soft voice, they say, "It's nice to say it."

"You're amazing," Adora blurts out, and Catra chuckles lightly. "But..."

"What is it?" Catra looks at her, slightly worried.

"Why not Spider-Woman?"

Panic bubbles up within them, but Adora is waiting, only curious, but they are scared. "I'm... non-binary."

Adora smiles brightly, and Catra feels their heart flutter from her positive reaction, that she has accepted them. "I feel like I should tell you something in return."

"Yeah?"

"I like you. I was worried about telling you, or if you asked about my sexuality, I wouldn't know what to say. I don't like boys, I don't like girls, I just like you."

Catra is silent, almost for too long, but they decide to hell with it, and kiss Adora. "I won't keep anything from you anymore," they say afterwards.

"I'm always going to be here for you."

Catra hugs her. Those are the words they need to hear -- needed to hear for *so* long, and now it was the time that they are ready to hear them, and accept them. Their father never said anything of the sort to them, not when they needed it the most. They weren't close, Catra had mixed feelings towards him, and they knew he felt the same way, and it was sad really. Adora has such a close relationship with her fathers, and Catra envied it, but they never admit it. Adora has always been Catra's first choice for emotional support, but after developing such strong romantic feelings for, they became increasingly distant, and they knew it hurt Adora, but they didn't want to say something that would make it awkward if Adora didn't reciprocate. They were so glad she does feel the same way, but being Spider-Man brings an added risk to being in a relationship, if they even decide they want to give a relationship a go. If an enemy found out who Spider-Man cares about, they will most certainly take them, threaten to harm them, to lure out the superhero. Catra didn't want that to happen at all; no matter how much they want to be with Adora, they weren't going to put a target on her back.

There's tears threatening to spill out, and they finally do when Adora hugs them back, telling them that they didn't have to struggle anymore, no more suffering in silence. Adora tells them she's proud of them, and unable to control themself, Catra cries even more. "I'm sorry," they manage to say, although it's quick and blubbered out of their mouth.

"You have nothing to apologise for, I can understand why you did it," Adora's voice is soothing to them, and they want to be held in her arms forever, but she senses they've stopped crying, and lets go. Catra wipes their eyes on the sleeve of their denim jacket, and they follow Adora inside for dinner. She's cooked chili without the mince meat, three different types of beans and pulses in a rich sauce, served with rice, because she knows Catra doesn't eat meat, and that it's one of their favourite dishes (that they barely get to have because they only eat when there's a tiny amount of time available in between work, school, and being Spider-Man).

Adora's birth mother, a single parent, died a few years ago, and Catra was there for them. They were only 12 at the time, but they understood what happened, and felt the grief as one. Adora's mother was someone who Catra was close to, seeing her as a mother figure in the absence of their own mother. Her death hit them hard, but not as much as Adora's family, of course. She was adopted by Bow's fathers. The funeral was hard to get through, she was such a lovely person, loved by everyone. If Adora's father hadn't left, Catra would have been amazed to see how he would cope with the loss of his wife. However, they felt it would foreign if it turned out he was much closer to his daughter now, all because of Catra's own father - who had done the opposite, and was pretty much neglecting Catra when their own mother died. Catra was thankful that Adora was part of a loving family; it was a large family, but still very loving. Catra envied it, but kept those feelings hidden.

Conversations over dinner are a much needed catch up between Catra and Adora's family, dare they say they felt happier for it, like life is normal now. Apart from the fact, after the spider bite, they seem to need to eat a lot more, or maybe it's just Catra realising how much less food they were consuming due to their poor

lifestyle and habits. Catra's phone pings in their pocket, and so does everyone else's. They all have the same notification; the Green Goblin attacks the city centre. Mentally, Catra groans. They click on the link to understand the situation, and with no doubt about, the Goblin wants Spider-Man dead and gone, and Adora has clicked the article as well, because Catra can tell she is looking at them. Adora attempts to kick Catra under the table so they would come up with an excuse to leave, but their spider-sense tells them to move their leg back, so she ends up kicking nothing. Catra smirks a little, because they can't help but automatically dodge incoming attacks, even minor ones. Adora tries again, but the same reaction occurs. In the end, she resorts to asking if she can talk to Catra outside, and they're standing on the door step once more.

"You should go."

"It's rude to leave in the middle of dinner."

"I'll save you some?"

"Great, thanks," Catra says before going to jump over the fence.

"Really? That's all it took?" Adora laughs as Catra easily lifts themself over the fence, climbing up the side of their house to their bedroom window.

It's a matter of seconds later when Spider-Man zips past the neighbourhood, heading to the town hall where some event is happening. The one that the Green Goblin has decided to target. They arrive at the scene, high up and in the shadows as they process the situation. First things first, help civilians leave the scene, even if it means holding up blocks of rubble for an absurd amount of time so no one would get crushed while the enemy can use the time to wreak more havoc, testing Spider-Man's ability to multitask, mainly by trying to accurately fire some webbing to save someone or catch some debris, while holding some rubble or a civilian, or catch two things (or people) at the same time. Luckily, their spider-sense would automatically make them dodge attacks, and also alert them to the direction of danger, so all they had to do was act, but it was easier said than done.

The police are on the scene, but as usual, have no chance of defeating someone like this, but they also don't like the fact that Spider-Man is around, even if he is doing pretty much all of their jobs. They enter the building, zipping to the ceiling to avoid a projectile. "Have you been standing here all this time?"

"Come down here and fight like a man!"

"Could I convince you to come up here and fight like a spider?" They pause for an answer, only receiving a glare. Well, he didn't want to play, but that didn't mean that Spider-Man didn't want to. "Ok, taking that as a 'no'," they say as they dodge a desk thrown at them. "What's your deal?"

"I want you dead."

"Yeah, did I really have to ask that?" they say to themself as they swing down to kick their opponent.

The fight is brief, but injuries are dealt to both sides, as Catra soon realises that they are unable to dodge three quite large items thrown with precise aim at different angles, and an explosive, if they wanted to save a toddler. They saved the child, gently swinging them outside the building to safety, but not without taking quite a blow, and they knew something had impaled them. The goblin escapes, not that it came as a surprise to anyone, and Spider-Man ends up calling on Adora to try and dig out some shrapnel from their leg. She wipes the cut on Catra's cheek, as they take a swig from the bottle of vodka as they look at the stitches Adora has put in the gash in their leg.

"Can we talk now?" she asks, throwing away the bloodied rags and bandages.

"About what?"

"Us. Are we together?"

"I don't want you to get hurt. Supposing this goblin guy knows who I am? They'll know you as well, they might hurt you."

"I don't --"

"I *do* care, Adora. They'll sure as hell take you, but I can't guarantee your safety. Look what he did to me, he's managed to hit me, pretty fucking badly. I'm not sure if I can fight him, limit hits to myself, and look out for you at the same time. I'm sorry, Adora, I can't lose you, even if it means not being with you."

Adora frowns before sighing, "Ok," she pauses. "But what about *after* you defeat him?"

Catra laughs a little. "Sure, we can be together," they agree. They kiss her cheek, "You want to stay the night?"

"I was wondering how long it would take you to ask," she smiles. "Someone has to make sure you wake up on time."

"I didn't know we were married," they joke, but there's a silence that follows where they're both thinking about how it would feel to be married -- live together properly. A life together. Deep down, Catra knows it isn't possible, as much it stings, to protect her, they have to leave her. But not yet. Not now. Deciding not to add to the topic any further, Catra gives Adora one of their t-shirts and pair of shorts to sleep in, even if the t-shirt is over sized, it almost acts like a night dress on it's own for Catra, but not so much for Adora.

They're laying in bed, Adora is fast asleep the moment she curls up under the covers, while Catra can't. They're increasingly worried for Adora's safety now that they've decided to be in a relationship. It's what Catra has wanted for so long, but now that they have it, they don't want it. It's not that they don't have

feelings for her, it's primarily for her safety. Even as Spider-Man, they can't promise her that they will be able to find her if she gets taken. They can't promise her that she won't be hurt if she is taken, and after all of that, they can't promise her that they will be able to protect her while fighting if there isn't a safe exit for her to follow, so she's forced to stay around while they fight.

The more they think about it, the more the possibilities seem endless, and their heart is hammering against their chest, that they only noticed just now. They're struggling to breathe. The thought is terrifying to them. They're only 17, ok, almost 18, but still. They are young, still figuring regular life out, never mind the added life of being Spider-Man and having to master their powers, hand to hand combat, and to think quick to deal with whatever enemies they may face. They are the only option available to fight enemies such as the Green Goblin because no one else can match him, nor lay a hit on him. However, if they can find out who the Green Goblin really is, it may boost their chance of winning a lot. The only lead is that he despises Spider-Man, which could be said for quite a wide range of people, so it doesn't exactly help, but, if they know Catra personally, it will definitely narrow down the options. The only question is; who on Earth hates them so much? Their father? That's a thought they can laugh at, although possibly, they doubt it. They really doubt it, even if their nervous laugh says otherwise. They begin to list the people they know well, it's definitely not Bow or one of his fathers, but it may be one of the people at school, so they list the people who they don't like at school, and they know the feeling is mutual. At work, they rule out their boss, so the only possible option from work is Will, and they suddenly remember how he was acting last week. He really doesn't like Spider-Man, and Catra's spider-sense did warn them of the dangers surrounding them. His arm, too. He couldn't have injected himself with something, right? He surely wouldn't be that crazy.

But he might. It hurts to think about, but now that Catra thinks about it, it adds up. He wasn't working on any cars that day, they noticed the metal work that was in the process of being welded, the deep green metal paint on the side, how short tempered he seemed; how he really seemed to get worked up when Catra said Spider-Man was doing a good thing, that *really* seemed to press his buttons.

Sighing, Catra looks over at Adora, still fast asleep. If Will is the Green Goblin, he will take Adora, but that's only if he finds out that Catra is Spider-Man, and they are 100% certain that he will only find that information if Catra tells him about it themself, so it didn't worry them too much. The thought settles their mind, and they fall asleep soon after.

Chapter End Notes

> i have a special sidestory planned as today (14th july) is nonbinary day, however it takes place after part one and before part two of this fic, so i have decided not to publish it until the timing is right as there is spoilers.

healing

Will doesn't turn up to work on the weekend, leading Catra's suspicions sky high. They're working with Adora to think of ideas of how to confirm that he is the Green Goblin, and presents Adora with Spider-Bot. "We can use this!"

"Which is?" Adora squinted her eyes at the little robot in their hands.

"A spider-robot with a camera connected to this," they hand her the control pad.

"How are you so clever?" Awe is laced in her voice, and Catra likes it.

"It was actually really easy -- oh, wait, I see what you mean by that. Anyway, we could use this to follow Will, see if he has the goblin's equipment."

"Like you have Spider-Man's suit so brilliantly hidden?" Adora gestures to the suit, stuck to the ceiling with webs.

"Yes? I practically live alone, it's ok."

"Which reminds me, I got you a present, which you won't mind if you live alone," Adora says and unzips her backpack. With that wording, Catra's mind imagines that it's some vulgar thing from that weird sex shop located near the outskirts of town. Instead, Adora hands them a jewellery box, smooth with a velvet cover.

Catra takes it and opens it up. Inside is a pair of stud earrings of Spider-Man's mask. "These are amazing, where'd you get them? I've not worn earrings for so long, they kind of get stuck with the mask and everything," they say as they take the butterfly off one and proceed put it in the empty piercing in their ear lobe.

"I made them myself."

"That's so cool," they grin as they put the second stud in.

"Catra," she sighs. "You know it's your birthday, your 18th?" she asks, doubt washing over her face.

"I knew something was coming up, it just slipped my mind. I've been really busy, you can't blame me."

"I don't know to do with you," she pinches the bridge of her nose, but she's smiling all the same. "Anyway, I figured you would want something more than just some earrings, I also got you an ear piece because you've already cracked your phone. It might be an idea now to get a small one for Spider-Bot, so you can hear what's going on where it is."

"You're full of good ideas," Catra chuckles. "Thanks, by the way, you've always gotten me something on my birthday. My dad never bothers, I expect you already knew that, though."

"Catra, that's awful. He doesn't do anything?"

" *Oh* . No," they laugh, hoping it would cover up their hurt at the truth. Adora frowns, taking their hands in her own. "You're lucky,

you know, the way you found a new family you after your mum died."

"I'm not, Catra. My fathers are just being fathers to their children. Bow is a childhood friend, and he knew I had no where to go . You're not to blame. You were six, you didn't know what happened. He should had been there with you, not leaving you on your own."

Suddenly, Catra hugs her. "Thanks, Adora," they try to remain strong.

Adora smiles a little - almost melting into their embrace - before asking them to show her what the little robot can do.

"It's like taking a dog out for a walk," Catra comments, making Adora laugh as they walk along the street, Spider-Bot in front of them as Adora controls it.

"It works better since I'm allergic to dogs," Adora states.

"Then how come you like hanging around --"

"Catra! She's actually very nice, but I know you hate everyone I talk to."

Catra simply shrugs as they walk up the path to their house, Adora almost tripping them up on purpose with Spider-Bot.
"Hey!"

"What?" Adora smirks as she follows them inside, and Catra surprises them when the control pad is suddenly taken from her grasp by a web. "That's cheating!"

"Is it?" Catra muses as they throw the control pad up and down in their hand. "It's a way of life now. It's kind of fun that you know, because I can do things like this all the time."

"Please, don't."

"Can't promise anything," they say in a playful tone as go upstairs. A minute or so later, they slide down the stair rail as Spider-Man. "I'll be back."

Adora smiles and watches as they leave. To pass the time, she debates watching some TV or doing something like cleaning (because the house needs it), or cooking (because Catra needs it).

They sit on the roof top of an apartment block, control pad in hand, as they watch the camera feed of Spider-Bot going about New York, following their co-worker/first proper enemy. A part of them really wants this hunch to be wrong, they've worked together for so long, they were close friends. Does every positive thing in Catra's life have to be cancelled out by a negative? They were getting sick of it if that was the case. They watch and control Spider-Bot, following the male to the outskirts of town where a deserted warehouse was. Spider-Bot scuttles inside quick before the doors are closed, and one fault is that it can't look up or jump, but it can turn around in a circle (and it has night-vision), which isn't exactly useful because there's no proof of anything the same height, or on the floor. There's table legs and stuff Catra can't make out, but the microphone picks up a distinct metallic sound, and they listen closely, before they hear Will talk to himself. Apart from thinking he must have a few screws loose, Catra has to laugh, more or less a coping mechanism now that their best friend wants to kill their alter-ego, or really, them. Catra stops listening and starts looking around to see if there is a gap between the door and ground that Spider-Bot can fit through, but it looks like it will be stuck there until he leaves, so Catra takes this chance to swing by the place. They don't really want to ambush it as they don't know what exactly they're dealing with on

the inside. They wait on the roof, the doors finally open and Spider-Bot makes it's way out, and Catra fires a web at it, and it zips up to them before Will can even notice.

They attach Spider-Bot to their side with another web, crawling around the building to see if there's a way to sneak in that's high up. There's a window, well, there's no glass, and it's poorly boarded up, Catra pulls off the three thin planks of wood, sticking them to the wall as they climb inside, jumping to the ground. Even if they didn't need glasses anymore, it seems night vision wasn't one of their abilities, so they use the torch on their phone instead, and take pictures of their findings. They might sure not to stay long, leave the same way they entered, and put the boards back on the window before going home.

"Are you not going to take that off?" Adora asks, standing in Catra's bedroom with the pictures printed on paper, and Catra tugs the mask off.

"Better?"

"A little. Do you think something will happen? Is that why you've not taken the suit off?"

"Do you have any idea how hard this is to put on?" Catra huffs.

"Oh, wait, is that *all* you have on?"

Catra doesn't answer, instead looks to the picture in their hand. "So, I think it is him."

"Ok," Adora drags out, still amused by their ignorance to her question. It's a genuine question, and she now assumes that they have nothing on under the suit. Well, maybe underwear, but they never said. Adora knows for a fact that Catra doesn't own any bras, and she wishes she could have the luxury of not wearing them as well, because all they do is hurt. "Are you planning to fight him tonight?" she goes back to the more important subject at hand.

"I can't risk leaving it any longer, because the longer I don't do anything, the higher the chance that he might hurt someone when I'm unable to help."

"There will be times like that..." Adora has to remind them, "I know you want to, but you can't always save everyone. It's unfortunate, but true."

"I know," Catra mumbles, "but the sooner I get him off the street, the better." They are distracted by the oven dinging downstairs, and Adora smiles.

"I made you mac and cheese," she smiles.

Catra smiles, already going downstairs, "I've not had that for ages."

"I know. I also know how much you love it."

Catra chuckles as they go into the kitchen, as the woman following them rolls her eyes as Catra opens the oven, not with their hands, but using their web shooters.

"Can't you do anything normally anymore?"

"Nope!" they flash a grin, almost smugly.

Although it proves to be a more efficient way, in some bizarre world, since it's quicker when you don't have to physically move to the cupboard with the plates in, then the drawer to get a spoon to serve with, and back over to the counter where the dish is.

They both sit on the sofa, watching the news on the television as they eat dinner. Catra wouldn't normally watch the news, in fact, they never did until they got bitten by that radioactive spider. Since then, they feel like they *have* to watch it and analyse each and everything crime related story.

The headlines recently have been about Spider-Man, not that they expected much else, but of course, the news reporters are asking if Spider-Man will fight the Green Goblin again. Obviously, that answer is a definite 'yes', even if it is made personal now due to the relations between the two opponents. Catra expects the Green Goblin's identity to be revealed in his mugshot, and they have already decided on what they will do when that information is leaked to the public who they have apparently sworn to protect; they believe that they are going a great job so far.

Suddenly, the programme is stopped by a new story, the breaking news being about the Green Goblin being spotted, and Catra is gone before Adora can even comprehend it all, their empty plate and fork dropping down onto the sofa in their absence. Sighing, she watches the news, which she expects to be a live broadcast, but all the screen shows is that the programme has been interrupted as they try to figure out what to broadcast next after the last reveal, and Adora ends up channel surfing instead to find something that is worth while, and also hopes that Catra is back

soon, because she's even more worried about them now that they are swinging around being Spider-Man, and risking their life to save others. She knows that Catra went through a stage where they didn't think their own life was worth much, and she worries that if they slip back into that mindset now, they may just take the 'heroic death' route and make a mistake on purpose, while the media all praise Spider-Man's efforts to combat crime through out the city of New York.

They're hanging upside down from the ceiling of the Green Goblin's warehouse, another trademark Spider-Man pose. It's dark, but their spider-sense can take care of that part. A lot of the time, they would act without realising due to it, and it surprises them at times because their reflexes were never that great, but it doesn't the weirdest 'skill' they had gained recently. Taking a deep breath, they lay in wait, as if they really are just waiting for their prey to hitch up, and they might well do that if they fire a web at the right moment, to take them off guard. It will work, unless the lights actually work in this warehouse, but the ceilings are high, and most people don't look at the ceiling when they first walk into a room, never mind if it is their base of operations. Well, maybe more people might do that if they knew that it is likely Spider-Man is around, and will want to try and take them down.

They almost doze off while they wait, but hearing the door open makes them come back to the world of the living, and they smirk to themself under the mask. They fire webs at the table to pull it up, sticking it to the ceiling before using a line of web to swiftly lower themself down before swinging as they kick the Green Goblin, the two acts being done in a matter of seconds, before their opponent had time to react to it at all.

Except someone turns the lights on, and Spider-Man turns to see the Green Goblin by the light switch, and they turn back to see what poor soul they have just sent flying with that kick. Not wanting to let his accomplice escape, they take them by the jaw and throw them towards the nearest wall, and web them to it, only to narrowly back flip to dodge an incoming projectile. It turns out to be a smoke bomb, so they shoot a web and pray it lands on a wall so they can gather their thoughts safe and sound up on a wall again, yet it must have been their opponent's direction, or maybe he grabbed it instead, because he pulls Spider-Man towards him, and there's no time for them to release the web before his knee meets their stomach. The armour doubles the impact, and they can't focus on anything else but trying to recover, not try and move a muscle to take themself away to have a moment to think about how to proceed, which is probably the best option. A minute without an attack from either party, Spider-Man dares to move, and that's when their opponent unleashes his fury; kicks upon kicks, punches upon punches, and another smoke bomb. Coughing from all the variables, they barely manage to swing up to the ceiling, seconds away from the Green Goblin crushing one of their web-shooters.

Clinging to the ceiling, they're breathing heavily as they try and sense which part hurts the most. Not the reality that this is Catra's closest friend, but which beating has caused them the most damage. The bruises will be angry and dark, they know that much, but they can feel something stinging, like a cut that has sucked in the material of their suit to cover itself up, and they feel their body irritated by the fibres of the suit in a fresh wound like this. They can feel the blood, and then they realise there's more than just one of these injuries. The armour of the Green Goblin's

must have sharp metallic points on the hands, and the toes of the boots, because that's the only way that they can imagine this extent of damage being dealt.

They still have their web shooters, so they still have a chance. So they unstick from the ceiling and drop down on their opponent, dodging his fist that was up in the air, hoping to impale Spider-Man on their way down, with a web across his neck, they attempt choking him, but he flips them off, over his shoulder, but they shoot a web and swing back around, clocking him with a right hook while upside down, before the web takes them to the wall. They crawl up to the ceiling, their best friend in all of this, and the Green Goblin takes the bait perfectly. During the previous attack, Spider-Man swiped a smoke bomb, which they planned to use in this next part. They drop the smoke bomb so it lands next to their opponent's feet, and when smoke bellows out, they pull the webbing off the heavy metal table that was stuck to the ceiling at the start of the battle, and listen out for the impact of the table hitting the Green Goblin, and the Green Goblin hitting the floor. They drop themself down on the table, their full weight along with the momentum of the jump down from the high ceiling.

They jump, web the table somewhere behind, and still in the air, they fire two webs, one to each hand of their enemy, and webs also remove the mask of the Goblin. Standing on the ground, they take the extra precaution of webbing his feet, and then his hands again. They watch as Will's face is revealed, twisted in pain, and Catra feels their heart drop. "Fuck," they say, forgetting to use their deeper voice for Spider-Man, but they can't just hope that Will is in too much pain to recognise Spider-Man as his close friend, so Catra pulls their right hand into a fist, and in one swift hit, they knock him out.

Sirens are in the distant, and they make their escape, assuming that Adora must have contacted the police just in time. It's raining while they make their way back to their home, and Adora. Speaking of, they spot her on the empty high street. They hang upside, appearing behind her. "Hello, stranger," they say in their Spider-Man voice, making her jump slightly.

"I was getting you medical supplies, I assume you need them?"

"So badly," they laugh, as Adora tugs their mask down their face, and Catra exhales weirdly as the rain enters their nose, shaking their head.

Adora chuckles, apologising. With that out the way, she gives them a meaningful kiss before replacing their mask. They depart soon after, not wanting to be seen together.

Catra is in their room, back before Adora, but it hasn't stopped them from peeling off their wet costume and mask, and seeing the damage done. There's bruises, of course there are, but that's not their main concern. Their main concern are the various cuts and slashes. There's one on their upper right arm, two on their left leg (shin and thigh), a graze on their right knee (which doesn't bother them too much, although it stings like crazy), they can't see the few scraps along with a jagged laceration across their back, but they can see the three on their torso. There's a particularly bad one, small but deep, on their chest, and a light one on their stomach. It didn't seem as bad as what they imagined when they didn't see it, or fully know of all of them. There is something they remember their teacher saying that the

brain will always make the injury worse upon seeing it. If you don't look, you don't know the extent, and you won't panic as much, especially if you are someone who overreacts a lot at the sight of blood. Just because some injuries bleed a lot (like head injuries), it doesn't necessarily mean they are horrific or life threatening.

Still, Catra is back with their trusty bottle of vodka as Adora cleans and dresses each wound, sticking the sides of some together with Steri-Strips because neither wanted to go through the process of stitching up wounds. "Jesus," Catra sighs (part of them finding this somewhat amusing), when Adora is finally done, and she helps Catra slip on a loose white t-shirt, not so much any trousers because Catra doesn't think they need to bother, and they don't really want to stand up when it hurt so much just to move their upper body to put that t-shirt on. "Thanks, by the way. I probably wouldn't have done such a thorough job on my own."

"You don't need to thank me, I'm only trying to not let you go septic."

Catra laughs at Adora's reply. "I know. I guess I'm a bit useless now, Spider-Man wise and partner wise."

"Partner?" Adora looks at them and Catra nods.

"Don't you remember? I thought we agreed the other day, you so desperately wanted to be with me, and I said after the Goblin is behind bars."

"You mean, I can't cuddle up to you because you're so beat up?"

"I can't even move. I can't lay on my side, stomach or back, how am I going to sleep?" The sudden realisation of that makes their face drop, because sleeping is something they love, and how serious their expression is makes Adora laugh. "How long will it take for them to heal? For me, remember I heal faster than literally everyone else on this planet now."

"How's your leg? I took the stitches out from the first fight."

"When did you do that?"

"How much vodka have you drunk?"

"Don't ask," they hide the bottle behind the pillow. They look at their leg, the wound Adora is talking about. It has been four,

maybe five days, and without the stitches anymore, it has appeared to be just a scar now, and even Adora is shocked because an hour ago, it was still weepy and a little bloody, especially when she had started to take out the stitches, and she was by no means a medical professional, she just simply tried her best.

"I guess it's healed then," Adora mutters, mostly to herself in amazement.

"People can go three days without sleep?"

"If you want to go insane, then by all means, try it. You're getting some sleep some way or another, Catra," Adora tells them, taking on the role of a doting wife.

"How? Do you expect me to stick myself to the ceiling with my own web shooters?" Catra replies with sarcasm laced in their words. Of course, the sarcasm goes unnoticed.

Adora stares at them, and Catra wishes they never said that, or that one of their powers was to turn back time so this conversation never happened. Yet, Adora is on board with the idea, much to Catra's dismay and very slight fear of what could go

wrong with it all. It suddenly occurs to them that they should really make a second pair of web shooters, as back up ones, in case an enemy destroys them, not for Adora to practice with.

Catra sighs as they stick to the ceiling, and Adora is trying to figure out how in God's name Catra uses these things, as she snaps on their web shooters to her wrists.

"Your middle and ring finger," they repeat for the fourth time, and finally, Adora gets it to work, but it's only a very minor success in the grand scheme of things, and what they are trying to accomplish here. " *Ow!"* Catra winces as they feel something hit the bad cut on their back.

"I'm so sorry!" Adora exclaims, trying to take off the devices now. She's obviously panicking, so Catra attempts to help.

They sigh, letting their feet off the ceiling, their finger tips being the only thing holding them to the surface above as they effectively dangle from the ceiling. "Forget it, I'll do it myself," they say, hoping they didn't come across as being irritated by the brunette's incompetence. They pray Adora doesn't get annoyed with them, but what they don't know is that Adora really can't become annoyed with Catra because she knows they've been

through a lot, and the ever-looming thought that their father is a neglectful piece of shit is something that really gets under their skin, especially when they live next door to Adora, who has a wonderful relationship with her own family, and it's only hit Catra worse due to the two of them both losing their mothers, and the extreme opposites their lives are like after the event.

Luckily, Adora agrees, and throws up the web shooters to them. They click them to their wrists, one hand on the ceiling as they do this. They say good night to Adora, who repeats it and leaves, not wanting to get tangled up in this.

Catra crawls over to a corner of their room, hanging by their feet before crafting some sort of web cocoon, and prepare to sleep until fully healed, or healed enough that one part of their body is available for them to sleep on. Although, being fully healed would be much better, it means they can get up to more Spider-Man stuff sooner, and not risk making any injuries worse than when they started off. Still, it's quite snug and cozy in the make-shift cocoon, and with that thought, they fall asleep.

decisions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra wakes up, almost falling onto the floor when they realise the cocoon has disintegrated. It's dark outside, but they also have no idea how long they have been sleeping for. Checking their phone won't help because they can't remember the day or date because they're still sleepy and not fully with it. They move their arm, no pain. They move their leg, no pain.

The blond smiles as they take scissors and cut off the bandages and gauze patches. They rub their bicep, nothing out of the ordinary, just a flush scar, one that can only be seen, not felt. It will probably fade in a few days time. They pull on a pair of sweatpants and check their phone to see any headlines about Spider-Man. Then they remember something, and panic wells up inside them.

The fact that Adora kissed them in the rain, while they were upside down. A *proper* kiss, not just a peck. It was fuelled by relief that Catra survived the battle against the Green Goblin. Catra feels their face heat up at the thought. It's eleven at night, but they can see a light on in Adora's room, so they climb out the window and jump over to the wall of the house next door, and sticking to wall as they knock on the window. Adora comes over and opens it, laughing as Catra pops into view, but she steals a view at those *biceps* being treated so well in the short sleeved t-shirt. "It's only been an hour," Adora tells them, and Catra looks shocked that so little time has gone by, then they remember the synthetic webbing does disintegrate after an hour. Still, being in some form of cocoon boosted their already impressive healing

factor tenfold, so they decide to only use it when the situation is most dire.

"I'm fully healed," they smile.

"Do you want to come in? I'm still not used to this being so casual."

"Clinging to walls is like one of the most normal things I can do!" they try to protest, but Adora's face says it all, that being able to crawl up walls, stick to walls and stand up on walls to walk or run is still not very 'normal' in pretty much everyone's eyes.

Catra climbs in the window and Adora smiles at them, mostly looking in amazement and admiration. "Don't you forget, we leave school soon," she reminds them, because it's almost guaranteed that they have forgotten all about it, especially since this is the same person who forgot their own birthday.

"We do?"

"Yes, Catra, we do."

"Oh, right," they laugh at their own mistake. They've become so preoccupied with being Spider-Man that they've almost forgotten that they have school to focus on, and a weekend job. "What time is it?"

"Ten o'clock."

"Is that all?" Catra sounds surprised by that, as if they expected days to pass by as they slept away the hurt, quite literally. Of course, mental health hasn't been discussed, and someone should really check how Catra is coping after being forced to fight one of their closest friends to save the city and it's people from more destruction.

"How are you?"

"Fine."

"Really, Catra."

"I'll get over it... one day," they mumble, knowing they won't. The fact they still feel the anger and hurt mix together and combine into something they don't know how to handle or express, should be enough to tell they aren't alright. In the morning, they'll confront Will, face to face. Yet, only one person will be able to get the truth out of the prison officers, and it won't be 'Catra the visitor', that's for sure.

For now, they want to focus on their relationship with Adora, who just wants to go to bed. Understandable. Catra lets her, leaving her to do so. Still, they have too much energy, so they decide to suit up and swing around the city to kill some time, and probably stop some crimes.

It's five in the morning by the time they return, and they fall asleep on their bed without taking the suit off, not even the mask. They sleep for an hour, their alarm waking them up so they can get ready for work. They shower, get dressed, and leave.

Catra sees Adora locking her front door. "Hey," they smile.

"Hi. Sleep well?" She walks over to them, and they proceed to walk into town together, hand in hand.

"Yeah, when I finally got back home, that is."

"Late night?"

"Five in the morning. I wish I could say I was out getting smashed like all the other teenagers. How many teenagers do you know who routinely stop crimes?"

"And save cities? Just one, and they never fail to impress me," Adora answers, even if it is a rhetorical question she's answering.

"Do you believe that everything happens for a reason?" Catra suddenly asks, and they desperately need an answer.

"Yes. I believe you were bitten by that spider for a reason, because bigger threats to the city will happen, and they need someone who is capable of taking it down."

"Spider-Man will *always* have enemies," they mumble, before giving Adora a prompt goodbye when they realise they're nearing the coffee shop.

"You don't want a coffee?" she jokes.

Catra rolls their eyes playfully before walking away. They arrive at their place of work and take off their denim jacket, hanging it up on a peg before pulling on their mechanic overalls, only halfway, and they tie the sleeves around their waist before checking in with their boss.

"Catra, can I have a word?" he asks before he tosses a set of car keys over to them. "Mercedes keys for after, brake pads."

"Sure," they say as they catch the keys in one hand, almost too quick on the mark, and their boss notices and comments on their reflexes. He swiftly moves on with the conversation, saying that he will be offering them a promotion of some sorts, a higher pay due to having less staff members, when the company only had four employees before Will. Catra agrees, saying that they finish school soon, so they'll be available on weekdays as well, not just weekends now. He smiles.

"Very well. I look forward to having you around more."

"Thanks," they smile before getting to work with the Mercedes parked out the front. They take it into the garage to replace the brake pads. It's quick, much easier to work with now than before the spider bite, so it meant they can work faster, get more cars fixed up, and it was something they needed due to being the only mechanic working today. The other one (who is supposed to be

covering for the one on holiday) called in sick, and Catra didn't mind doing it all alone, they much prefer it, but it can get a bit much because apparently everyone decided to book an appointment today.

A full service takes a while, especially when the car is practically falling apart. Catra sighs, staring at the car while they sway side to side in the wheelie chair. Soon enough, their boss has a free moment from dealing with the customers, and he comes to help. "Don't know where to start?" he asks.

"No. There's so much here. I barely touched the left wing mirror and it fell off, so I'm just sitting and looking."

He laughs a little, telling them to leave it with him, and they can go on their break.

The two of them work until the end of the working day (although they finish later than usual), taking turns in fixing cars or dealing with payments and drop offs. Catra pulls on their denim jacket, and decides to ask their boss something out of the blue. "Do you know if they are allowing visitors to the Raft?"

"You want to visit Will?"

"Yeah," they confirm.

"I'm not sure. I don't know much about it, but I'm sure you can try," he tells them, and with that, Catra leaves.

"Hey," Catra says over the phone. The police staff working at the Raft don't allow visitors to meet with the in-mates in person, but Catra can also find a way around that in a way that no one else could.

"Hi," Will says after a few seconds of silence.

Catra doesn't know what to say, not as a friend. Not as someone who has to act like they don't know the entire story, even if they are a major part in the story, at least, part of them is. All they can think of is: "Why?"

"Spider-Man is bad, and the police, they're just regular people, so they can't stop someone like him. So I had an injection, one to make me strong."

"He still beat you," Catra blurts out before they even have a chance to process it. He sounded like a shell of his former self. Catra tried to remain strong.

"There's always next time!" he slams the phone down on his end, and Catra reluctantly puts their phone back on the holder. Sighing, they leave the prison, going around the back and slipping their backpack off their shoulder.

"Hey, Gobby!" Spider-Man greets the prisoner at his cell's barred window. "Hope you don't go too insane in solitary!" He goes to punch the thick metal bars, and Spider-Man laughs. "I wouldn't do that again, not unless you want to break your fist."

"One day, I'll squash you like the bug you are!" he seethes, but Spider-Man just shrugs.

"As you wish. See you," they say before letting go of the wall, falling out of sight before swinging, and a web picks up their backpack, and they throw it on their shoulder, before swinging with the opposite arm to put their arm through the other strap.

They make it back home, climbing into their room via the window. Dumping their backpack, they pull off the suit and mask, putting it into the backpack after taking their civilian clothes out, throwing them onto the chair in the corner. They take a quick shower -- ok, an hour long shower, before they get dressed into what they normally wear to sleep in, a loose t-shirt with short sleeves and regular loose pyjama bottoms. They flop onto their bed, letting the tears finally fall.

Laying in bed after a small nap, they scroll through various social media apps on their phone, not so much looking at posts or stories of people they know, like Adora or people from school, but of the posts tagged with '#Spider-Man'. Harsh comments are almost impossible to find due to the flood of praise and support coming from the majority of users. A slight smile is on their face, amused from the lengths some people will go to to try and be negative, and end up sounding flat out ridiculous. The Daily Bugle article catches their eye, the newspaper has always been so negative and not accepting of Spider-Man. Although, if Spider-Man left, Catra knew that the newspaper would soon change their mind when the crime rates rise again. Which reminds them, *they can never stop being Spider-Man.*

They will always be Spider-Man.

Spider-Man will always have enemies.

Enemies that are likely to be stronger than the last.

There's no way that Catra can have Adora connected to them, it's too much of a risk, too large of a risk. They won't have it. The

only way to keep Adora safe is to cut ties with her completely. Even if it will hurt the both of them, it will hurt less than actually losing her. It's for the best. If someone finds out Catra is Spider-Man, there's little else Catra can do to prevent them finding out who they know in real life, who's closest, who's the one that can provoke them the most, who's the one who holds the most emotional baggage in Spider-Man.

Switching off their phone, Catra swallows as they just stare at the ceiling, trying their hardest to control their emotions and feelings in general. No one else is faced with such a choice, and they only have Adora's words earlier to comfort them, just a little anyway. In fact, it's not really helping them at all, it's just looming over them while they make a decision.

They graduate school tomorrow; something that is supposed to be a big day -- a happy day -- for all the students and their families, it's where family members come to support their child on the biggest day of their life so far, the final step into adulthood, and the big, wide world before them.

Were they really the right choice to become Spider-Man? Really, it wasn't even a choice because they had no say in the matter, it's just coincidence and being there at that exact moment.

But perhaps it was fate.

Catra is frowning as they watch students rush to families, everyone with happy faces as their near and dearest get the grades they need. They aren't envious or anything.

And then there was Catra. Alone. Their father didn't want to come because it would mean he would have to stop sleeping to support them, and he wouldn't be able to get any more sleep before he starts work in the evening, so it makes sense... but it still hurts. It hurts that he would rather sleep and focus on his job than his child graduating from high school, but it's also what Catra expected. It would be so much more of a shock to them if he turned around... and actually spoke to them. No, jokes aside, it would be more of a shock to them if he actually said he would go to their graduation. A very distant and probably very common parenting style, almost not even a *parenting* style. While he owned the house, it wasn't a home. Far from it. Catra has a lot of money saved up, and now they have finished school (and are 18 years old), they are fully intent in moving out if they find a cheap apartment to rent.

Sighing, Catra catches sight of Adora, a bright grin on her face as she waves, standing with her father and brother. A trace of a smile finds it's way onto their lips, but her utter joy is so infectious, they smile properly, shaking their head in the process.

Adora almost drags a very stubborn Catra over to her family so they wouldn't just stick out like a sore thumb (as they were pretty much the only person with no support from relatives, not that Catra is really bothered by that or anything, it's something they have become accustomed to over the years, both in school and at

home). "You're coming to dinner tonight," Adora tells her as they approach her family - Bow and his dads, his siblings all older, all moved away.

"Alright," they agree with a hint of defeat in their answer.

Adora notices. "Are you ok?" she stares at them, looking for any tell-tale signs that Catra is upset, and she is only able to do that because she knows them so well.

"Yeah," they force a smile, but it's not good enough for the brunette, who tries to make herself tall to give them a talking to.

"You will come to me if you feel down, because it's bad to bottle up your feelings." Another order, but Catra is also used to that.

"Yes, ma'am," they mock a salute, before climbing in the back of her father's car, along with Adora. The drive home is mostly the radio, the brief conversation about grades is very brief, as Catra doesn't want to talk about it. Besides, it's not like there is much to talk about, they got the grades they need, the grades they were expected to get, and that was that. Enough said. They get out the car and head up to the path of Adora’s house, when Catra has a thought.

"Adora, wait, I need to tell you something."

"It can't wait?" She turns to face them, hoping whatever it is can wait until after dinner.

"You're right, after dinner," Catra says. For two reasons; one, they don't want Adora to be upset over dinner (plus it would make things awkward), and second, Catra really wants a change of food, because as mentioned before, they have an awful diet. Yet since the spider-bite, diet doesn't seem to cause a problem with their physique.

They're sitting at the dining table, talking over dinner. Well, everyone but Catra, who only chips in now and again, mostly a one liner joke or a few sentences at a time. Now, Catra has never been a very talkative person, Adora knows this, but she also knows that something is quietly eating away at Catra, and they need to get a weight off their shoulders soon before they snap. Still, after dinner it would be, and she believes that there must be a reason for that decision as well. Catra stabs a chunk of carrot with their fork, now uncomfortable because they sense Adora is watching them, but for the life of them, they won't make eye contact with her.

As they finish up dinner, Catra helps Adora take the dishes out to the kitchen to load the dishwasher.

"Are you alright?" Adora asks, needing an answer to this question.

"I just need to talk to you, that's all. Could we go outside?"

"Yeah," Adora says as she presses the 'start' button on the dishwasher, and she heads outside with them, standing on the door step.

Catra is shifting their weight from one foot to the other, twiddling their thumbs, all while Adora is watching intently, and concerned.

"It's ok, Catra," she reassures, but it only makes Catra tell her something she really didn't want to hear, but deep down, part of her expected this to happen, but because it hurt to think, she pushed it to the back of her mind, convinced herself she was being stupid for thinking such a thing, until that exact sentence leaves Catra's lips.

"I think we should break up," Catra says, and then they pause for a few seconds before continuing. "I will always be Spider-Man... and he will always have enemies. I just can't risk someone on the

wrong side finding out who is behind the mask. If they can find that information, it's child's play to find out who I know. They'd go for you, I'm certain, and I can't lose you. While it hurts, to break something up before it even started, losing you would hurt more, and I don't think I can't deal with that at all."

"I understand," Adora eventually replies as she fails at blinking away tears. "I understand," she says more firmly. "Can we still talk?"

"I..."

"Actually, don't answer that, Catra. I'll see you around, yeah?" Adora turns to walk inside, shutting the door behind her, and Catra exhales.

They can hardly believe what just happened. It stings, and they want to tell Adora it's all a mistake, but it's been done now, and Catra can't bring themself to be *that* kind of person. The one who constantly breaks up with their partner, and their partner gets increasingly fed up by it.

They need to let off steam, and to know that this is definitely the right (and only) decision, so they do the one thing they know; don the suit of Spider-Man, and swing through New York City in all it's beauty at night.

The lights of the buildings effectively become a path for Spider-Man to follow, but they test themself, free falling until the very last second to fire a web and save themself from death's tempting arms.

As they swing through the night, Catra remembers what Adora's mother once told them, and they feel more confident in their decision.

"Sometimes we have to be steady and give up the thing we want the most. Even our dreams."

Chapter End Notes

the next 2 chapters will be the 2 side stories, but apart from that, this is the end of part one, i hope you have enjoyed! you are welcome to chat with me on tumblr, i think it is linked in the notes of this fic, but it is also on my profile

sidestory: celebrate

Chapter Notes

> originally written for nonbinary day, but i messed up my upload schedule

Even as a child, Catra never felt like a girl, so they always had short hair. They didn't feel like they were fully a boy, but they liked toy cars and action figures, while cringing at dolls and child make up kits. They despised dresses and skirts with a passion, and they still do to this very day. They felt so uncomfortable when their mum forced them to wear one to weddings or birthday parties, because 'Catra, you need to fit in. It's not lady-like to wear trousers.' What did Catra do? Well, nothing. They were below the age of six at the time, and when they were six, their mother passed away, and their father didn't give a shit what they wore, so as they grew up, they got to wear what they wanted, and grew to love cargo trousers, and purchased baggy t-shirts to hide their developing body. Part of them were so grateful that their father didn't give a shit in what they wanted to wear, or not wear (and avoid at all costs). Still, they never told their father that they were non-binary because he wouldn't react kindly. He would call it stupid, that it's just a phase, and they will come to their senses eventually. They were scared of that reaction actually happening, so they felt much safer if only they knew. They've always enjoyed being in their own bubble, that no one could pop (hopefully).

They felt alone, but they were fine with it, until new neighbours moved in opposite. They had one child; Adora, a daughter the same age as them. They went to school together and they were close friends, and Adora's mother was the mother figure in Catra's life, and she accepted them, embraced them for going against what is expected of gender stereotypes. Like all good things, they come to an end, and two years later, Adora's mother passed away.

Adora and Catra were 12 at the time. Again, they had lost a mother figure. Bow, their next door neighbour had gone to primary school with Adora, and had remained close friends, so his family adopted her. Yet, the two still felt a loss.

It was worse when their own mother passed, because Catra was six, unable to understand where their mother had gone, and the one person they needed wasn't giving them attention or taking time to help them process the event. As they grew up, they had little regard for their father, and they knew he felt the same way. If they were both in the house, they barely spoke or stayed in the same room as each other voluntarily. Like the kitchen, their father may be sitting there, and Catra would quickly make coffee or a sandwich and skulk back to their room before either of them felt like they had to say something. It has been a routine for so long, neither felt the need to make any sudden changes to it. One reason that Catra started working was to make enough money to move out. They earn a decent wage as a mechanic, deciding to work as one because their father already taught them about cars.

Still, their life changed dramatically for the first time in a while after the school trip to a genetics laboratory, where a genetically engineered spider passed powers and abilities that are rendered unbelievable until witnessed. While the spider died in the process, it could not stop Catra from wondering if other spiders (because there were other spiders) could mutate DNA like that, resulting in more people like them. It's probably unlikely, but it's a thought that they can spend too much time imagining the reality of.

A little bit of training, intelligence and getting creative, and Spider-Man was born. Viewed as a young man who put bad guys behind bars with quips and tricks, the public had no idea of the real identity of the vigilante, and if they ever found out, it would come as a shock. The people of New York would stop and stare, while some would take pictures, and recently, they would cheer for the masked hero going to tackle the threat, swinging above their heads like a trained acrobat.

So *many* threats.

But they wouldn't have so much fun if not for these villains, mostly created on accident just like Spider-Man was. The villains of this vigilante were also involved in genetic experiments gone wrong, some of them had awful experiences along the way, but at the end of the day, Spider-Man had to take them down if they posed as a threat to him, or the people of New York. Sometimes it was both. Ok, a lot of the time it was both. The villains were fuelled by their hatred of the wall crawler (a nickname given by various media outlets), and they knew how to lure him out, by putting the innocent (and helpless) in danger. Yet, fighting bad guys was part of the job, even if it was hard work, frustrating to no end, and got tiring at times, they wouldn't change it for the world. The best fights were ones that took place in a quiet area (no civilians to get hurt), and it was just Spider-Man, and the opponent.

The list is getting longer and longer, and it all started with the Green Goblin. He was just the beginning of Spider-Man's journey, and so far, Spider-Man has been tested and pushed more than the

hero would have liked. Whenever he got pushed down, he got back up. Newspapers praised him, all except the Daily Bugle, the police department were mixed, but the majority hated him, or just said so to avoid being fired. It didn't matter.

What did matter to the people was who. Who was behind the mask? An 18 year old student. An 18 year old who worked as a mechanic, and is head over heels for the girl next door. An 18 year old who endured hits and punches to save civilians, mostly older than their own age, and they risked their life every time a new threat rises. If they knew the truth, they would refer to the hero as a child, and while it all started in their last few weeks as a 17 year old, they were legally an adult, but they still couldn't legally drink. What would cause the most backlash would be if this 18 year old hero revealed their civilian identity, everyone would be quick to call them things like: female, a teenage girl, a heroine, Spider-Man is actually Spider-Woman, and they would surely speculate sexual orientation: lesbian. Perhaps Catra shouldn't get so worked up over simply words, but the subject mattered to them. Explaining the idea of gender neutral pronouns and non-binary people, it's something they really want people to understand, but the moment people discover that this hero is part of the LGBTQ+ community, that's all anyone will care about, and the people wanting others to respect the hero's pronouns will be drowned out by them. It concerns them, but they have to find comfort and strength in knowing their identity will never be revealed unless they so choose to release it to the public. If they never tell anyone, no one will find out, (a logic that is flawless yet full of naivety in the same breath). No one will be that interested in Spider-Man for that to happen, right? Of course not. It's not like Spider-Man is very popular anyway, and even the police haven't made any moves in on the person behind the mask because they have no leads to who it really is. They have better things to do than try and catch someone who's doing what the police should be doing. Well, minus the Green Goblin incident, and any other villains that come forward on his level or higher.

Catra likes being Spider-Man; it brings them a sense of purpose that they must fulfill, plus, it's fun to swing around New York City while probably giving some drivers a nervous breakdown with some of the stunts they pull off, or close shaves they've had with the traffic, all for the adrenaline rush that they love so much. If not for Spider-Man, Catra always wanted to enlist in the armed forces, especially if they didn't have enough money saved up for a small apartment, so as to get out of their childhood home as soon as they left school. They like to imagine that in both scenarios, they would have a 'heroic' death, protecting people. So in a way, maybe being Spider-Man was the better of two evils, as swinging around the city on their own was better than living in a trench, and working with other people to get the job done efficiently.

At school, Catra never told anyone about them being non-binary, nor request people refer to them by 'they/them' pronouns. They just wanted to make it through school, no bother what so ever. It was their last year in school, they've made it this far without sticking out of the crowd... too much anyway. They didn't dare say they liked girls either, as they didn't want to get bullied for that. They kept themself to themself, and it works brilliantly. No need to change their ways now. Still, it was obvious to them and Will how bad their crush on Adora was. Laughable, really. That no one else seemed to pick up on it. Perhaps Adora did, and she was just waiting for Catra to build up confidence and actually speak to her, and get used to actually speaking to her. If that had been her plan, it had really worked.

At home, well, it goes without saying that they were not going to tell their father about it, even if they were threatened with death, and the only way to live was to tell him that they were non binary,

and that he should refer to them using 'they/them' pronouns. In fact, he would probably die before he respected his child's one wish of their father. Catra is used to it, having a distant father. It's fine, really. It doesn't bother them as much as it used to.

Adora accepts them, and that's all that truly matters to them. Just one person, one who they care so greatly about, who actually accepts them for who they are, makes all the difference. It may seem like such a little thing in other people's eyes, who don't understand the enormity of it all for Catra, and others who feel the same way as them; that with time, they will also come across the right person/people who will accept them for who they truly are, living with no limits or restraints.

sidestory: the black cat

Chapter Notes

warning for smut. and implied toxic relationship
im currently editing the next few chapters to add some catra/adora scenes because there wasn't much of them, but for this to work, it needs more, so updates may be slower due to that

Discarding the grease stained pizza box, they pull their mask down again before pushing off their perch on the edge of the roof top to go about their routinely Spider-Man patrol, same thing every night for the far too long, already. Time really did go so quickly, for them at least, not so much the criminals they have put behind bars in the Raft, a high security prison, basically containing everyone who has tried to kill them over their time as Spider-Man, and part of them just wanted to drop by and taunt them, but not tonight. Tonight, there was something they wanted to check out. Recently, there's been sightings and news reports of a thief going by 'Black Cat', and as Spider-Man, Catra knows they have to be part of this. They're still hurting from everything that has happened with Adora, but they weren't going to put her in harm's way. They love her too much, and that's one problem, because it's frustrating Adora. They can't seem to get her to understand that if the wrong people know who Spider Man cares about, the higher chance they will locate Adora and use her to lure out Spider-Man. They can't face it. They can't handle a double life. They wish they never got bitten by that stupid radioactive spider in the first place, and just when they're thinking that, they automatically dodge to the right, sticking to the wall near the roof of the building, narrowly avoiding a grappling hook coming in their direction, and they know exactly who it belongs to: Black Cat. The thief lands on the roof, but she's leaning over the edge, face barely an inch away from Catra's own. They curse themself for blushing under the mask at the sight, and the thought of being played by such a woman.

"I thought I'd surprise you." Catra is sure that voice can't get any more seductive and alluring than it already is, until the owner seemingly plays with them even more. "You know, I've been wanting to get your attention for a while, Spider. I didn't know it would be so easy."

"No, you're just at the right time," they say, quiver in their voice that they want to slap themself for. Why are they nervous? They're practically begging to be teased right now. They want to move on from Adora, who is still pissed off at them for always changing their mind about being in a relationship or not, and it looks like the perfect opportunity has just presented themself right in front of them.

"Nervous?"

"No."

"I know a good place, it'll calm your nerves."

Catra climbs onto the roof, almost entranced by the thief, not just because of the skin tight suit that hugged her curves perfectly, or her hair, or her face, or her voice, but there's a certain elegance in the way she moves through the night, and it's careful, graceful, like a cat. Biting their lip, they try not to let their thoughts wander too much as they swing behind her, following her lead. They end up in a back alley bar, obviously abandoned, but, hey, free drinks! As well as whatever fun will follow the free drinks.

They go hard, double tequilas from the get-go, followed by whiskey and vodka. Mixers are not a part of this, nor should they be. The couple are giggly as they try out some sort of staggering slow dance, her hands on their shoulders, but they can feel them sliding up to remove the mask, but at this point, Catra can't bring themself to care, and lets her tug off the mask and toss it lazily onto the bar counter. Their hands travel from her waist to her hips as they just stare at each other, partly due to the alcohol making them slow, and partly due to taking in each other's appearance. Catra is the first to move, picking her up in one swift gesture, and her fingers are in their hair, smiling to herself. "You're so gorgeous," she slurs. "Why hide it?"

"It would ruin the surprise," they say, edging closer to her lips, so much that they brush against them as they speak. The kiss is increasingly rougher and harder, and Catra places the woman -- name still unknown to them -- on a bar stool. Nimble fingers find the zipper of her suit, "What's your name?" they ask, breaking the kiss so she can answer.

"Felicia," she smiles, and if Catra wasn't so drunk, they probably would have blushed upon noticing her face looked so pretty with that playful smirk. Felicia takes this opportunity to tug off their suit. "You?"

"Catra."

"Well, I can't wait to be screaming it," she grins, placing a kiss on their jawline while her hands run down their chest. Catra sucks in

a breath, alcohol clouding their mind as they lose themself, and any common sense along with it, as they feel their partner's hands pinch their nipples. They push the sleeves of Felicia's costume down her arms, caressing the smooth skin that reveals more and more of itself. Their nipples are hard, and they feel Felicia smirk against their skin as she kisses one of them. This is too slow, a fact they both agree on, so it doesn't take long for Felicia to be sat in a bar stool with Catra's head in between her thighs, their tongue licking the length of her folds, putting more pressure in the centre. The tip of their tongue flicks her clit, and Felicia tips her head back and moans.

"Fuck," Catra murmurs at the sound of it, repeating the action twice, enough to lead her on, but not even for her to enjoy. They want to tease her, but at the same time, they want to make her feel good, and fast, because they want nothing more than for her cum to gush out of her perfect folds, that Catra, in their drunken state, could quite happily worship. Their tongue slips through her folds, and Felicia grips the counter, her knuckles white as she attempts to not unravel herself just yet, their name letting slip, but it feels so right, and she practically yelps at the sudden pressure on her clit as two of Catra's fingers rub it vigorously. The pleasure is overwhelming, a much needed stimulus, and she lets herself go, moaning their name, as Catra laps up her cum, kissing her wet cunt briefly, the smirk on their face almost makes the woman weak, and they kiss her without wiping their mouth. Felicia is quick and rough to change their positions, but the brunet enjoys it, and the sight. "You know, you're really something," they comment, and the woman laughs lightly.

"I can say the same for you, you really know how to use your tongue. You must get a lot of girls, huh?"

"Not really," they say, hoping Felicia would get that they didn't want to talk about this topic, and she does because she nods.

"I'm gonna make you feel good, you deserve it," she says as she slips two fingers without warning, into Catra's moist pussy, her other hand pinching and toying with their left nipple. They sigh heavily and happily as Felicia takes it up a notch, thumb coaxing their clit, and she watches as their arousal gushes out onto the stool below, and she suddenly stops everything, unable to resist the urge that she has to taste them. She's rough as she licks their wetness, she's messy and there's no real rhythm as she hums briefly, and Catra almost cums right there and then as they moan out, knowing they must be drenching the woman between their thighs.

"Shit," they only mean to mutter the curse, but Felicia pressed their clit just at that moment, so they moan instead.

"You like that, Spider?" Felicia's far too happy with herself right now.

"What was wrong with 'Catra'?"

She laughs against their wet folds, "I'll only call you by your name if you say we can do this again."

"On one condition, you stop robbing people."

"Sorry, love. I can't, I won't rob you of an orgasm," she says as she rubs their clit.

"You know what I mean," Catra barely manages to say without moaning.

"Fine, for you," she agrees, and grants Catra their orgasm, and as much as she wants to have them completely dry, the more she licks up their cum and along their pussy, the more they produce, and she giggles when the overstimulation brings a second, more pleasurable orgasm with it. She kisses Catra, who is breathing heavily like she once was. "Swing safely home," she tells them.

"Same goes for you," they retort. "Unless, you want to go again?"

Felicia giggles, sitting in their lap. "If you insist," she purrs, their lips meeting.

This went on for six months, not without it's ups and downs. Felicia was only interested in Spider-Man, not Catra as a person, unless she was drunk, which would mean Catra was as well, so Catra never really cared, they just enjoyed the attention. The two acted as a stress

reliever for the other, convincing themselves that it was love they were both feeling, not lust. In the end, Catra broke up with her when they learnt Felicia was stealing again.

Meanwhile, the media spent the last six months flooded with the Spider-Man and Black Cat partnership/relationship, and a certain someone couldn't face opening their phone for fear of a news headline flooding their notifications.

[part two: the villains] the lizard

Chapter Notes

ok, its really obvious where a lastname should be used, but i'm not sure if catra has one?

also, part two takes part over years. the chapters are not in chronological order. spidey will fight these villains a lot, mostly off-screen, as these chapters focus on their first fights/first defeat

"I'm here to see Dr Curt Connors," Catra tells the miserable looking receptionist at Oscorp, who practically grunts the question of: 'what's your name?'

Catra tells her their name, and she grunts something that sounds like: 'to the left', so with the rather unhelpful instructions, they follow the sign pointing right that said 'laboratory', and they end up almost bumping into the one-armed man himself in the corridor. It saves them from wandering around aimlessly, but they just hope he will spare a moment of his time so they can offer a piece of advice that they know he needs, or the revelation of this medical advance would already be taking the media by storm.

"Dr Connors? I'm Catra. My mother used to work with you."

"Ah, yes, your mother’s name was Elizabeth, I believe," he gives them a smile. They nod. "Please, follow me."

Catra follows him, walking up the stairs to the floor he works at, looking at his experiments so far, all to do with regeneration, and they assume that he wants to regenerate his lost right arm. He has lost all of his lower arm, and only has about half of his upper arm. They want to ask how it happened, but they decide not to pry, and follow him into the room where he is holding the door open for them.

Sat in his office, Catra looks over at the scientist. "Your work is about taking cross-species genetics; reptile regeneration, and replicating it for a human -- or a mouse for a test subject first -- to improve health, right?"

"Yes. I'm afraid I haven't been able to figure it out, after all these years."

"I was looking through my mother's work, and found a decay rate algorithm equation that you might find useful," Catra takes out a piece of paper from their pocket and slide it over to his side of the desk. "With this, you should be able to regenerate limbs like you wish."

"Amazing," the man mutters as he looks at the missing equation. "How did you do it?"

"A lot of thinking." Catra chuckles, mostly out of politeness.

"How can I ever repay you?"

"You don't need to do anything. I like a challenge."

He goes into detail about the years of struggle he has had over this missing piece of the puzzle. Catra listens, and gets a tour of the lab and his test subject, a white mouse with three legs. His front right leg is missing, and Catra likens it to the doctor's own position. They feel bad for him, and the mouse too. Despite this, they make a mental note to have a pet mouse one day.

As soon as Catra exits the building, their spidey-sense alerts them of a small degree of danger, but they recognise it as just a warning, so they continue walking.

They go into work as they have a late start thanks to their boss saying they look like they could use a lie in, and they did. Did they spend it sleeping? Not exactly. They went to Oscorp instead. Yet they would be soon regretting that decision.

It's a relatively calm day, not much happening for Catra or for Spider-Man. They're just about to open their front door when they hear sirens. "I knew it was too good to be true," they mutter to themself.

By the time they arrive at the scene of the action, they only have a few seconds to process it all, before they swing into action, catching cars with webs as they are thrown off the bridge. "Incoming!" they shout as they kick the Lizard with both feet before saving another car from falling. There's a car in particular that a man calls them back, telling them his son is trapped in there. They are tasked with saving a kid or letting the lizard go, but when they look over, the lizard is gone.

"Don't worry," they tell him as they hold their web and slide down it, punching the back window of the car. The kid is screaming in the back seat, his seat belt holding him in place. "Hey, hey, hey, hey," they repeat, trying to coax the child. "It's alright, don't be scared. I'm gonna get you out of here." The child still screams, so they pull their mask off. "I'm just a regular person, look," they tell him, as the car creaks. "Do you want to hold onto this?" they reach their arm into the car to give the child the mask. "What's your name?" they look around for anything that may have his name on. They spot a bag with 'Jack' stitched into it. "I'm gonna come in and get you, ok, Jack?" they say as they begin to crawl into the car, and it creaks even more under the pressure. "I'll undo the belt," they tell him as they unclick the seat belt, and Jack falls into the back of the front seat. What neither of them knew was

that petrol is leaking down the side of the car, and not even a second later does a fire ignite most of the car, and it begins to fall. Spider-Man is quick to react, holding onto car by the edge of where the window would be if it wasn't broken, and a new web ensures they no longer fall. "Climb!" they shout, pleading at this point.

"I can't," Jack sobs.

"Yes! Yes, you can!" they answer immediately. "Put the mask on!" they pray as the car starts to fall apart. "It will make you strong."

Jack puts the mask on as Spider-Man sways while they try to hold the car and the web sticking to the bridge in place. It's straining them, and the fire is making everything worse, bits of the car falling into the vast river below. He begins to climb as Spider-Man asks if he can climb faster. He attempts to, as Spider-Man reassures him, yet it isn't fast enough. The car creaks, and it slips from their grasp. Automatically, they shoot a web to the child, pulling him out of the car, slowly bringing him up to them. They take the mask back as they pop the child over the side of the bridge before crouching on the railing. The man hugs his son, thanking Spider-Man over and over again.

Their heart slows from it's previous adrenaline-fuelled fast rate, and they swing by other cars or other people's shouts for help.

The police are soon on the scene, and Spider-Man takes their leave.

By the next morning, the police have started a man hunt for both Spider-Man and the Lizard due to the confrontation on the Williamsburg Bridge. It's insane, Catra thinks, because Spider-Man was witnessed saving people, returning kids to parents, preventing cars from falling into the body of water below.

Saved lives.

Saved lives that the Lizard wanted to take.

They try not to get angry about it, but they have their suspicions about who the Lizard could be. A certain someone who researches a reptile's regeneration. They swing around the city, failing to gain access into Oscorp, but they know just the person who would be able to do that, and leave her a text. After another tussle with the Lizard, they notice tiny lizards all collecting on a drain cover, and that's all they need to know as they come up with a plan, and descend into the sewers themself while they wait for their partner to respond. With a single web, they wonder what the hell they are

doing as they go deeper and deeper underground. There's probably some kind of hide-out for their opponent.

In the centre of the sewer, there are four different lines they could go in, but they stay in the middle and fire numerous webs in each direction, and tie them in the middle. There's quite a collection, so they lie down and play a game on their phone. It's quite a wait, but they soon stop when a vibration on one of the webs (and their spidey-sense tingles) makes them put their guard up, and they web their phone to the wall of the sewers, and crouch in the direction of the web where something is approaching.

They're ready to attack, until they see it's just one of those lizards from earlier, and then another, and another, and it's almost like a vanguard of little lizards coming from every direction. They dare to call it cute, but their spidey-sense is going hay-wire, directly behind them, but by the time they dare to turn around, the Lizard attacks, holding Spider-Man on their own spider web, and they curse for their webbing for being so strong, until it slowly starts to ping off the walls.

"You stopped me once, you won't stop me again." Monstrous claws shred Spider-Man's suit, three large gashes carved into their chest, but the webs can't hold this weight for much longer, and Spider-Man webs their phone, swinging it to knock the Lizard on the head. It catches him off guard as a minor success, but as a result, the webs give in and they fall into the water below. Yet, it doesn't stop him from fighting, and Spider-Man is too concerned

about trying to come out of this alive than they are about how this is filthy sewer water. This is no longer about defeating the Lizard, it's a matter of survival. They manage to kick off the reptile and their legs and arms fail as they attempt to swim fast, yet the current of the water pulls them in the direction they want to -- need to -- go. But the current is not fast enough, and this is not Spider-Man's habitat, so the Lizard is gaining on them fast, until Spider-Man hits one of metal bars out the way of a small opening, just big enough for them to squeeze through without the first bar in the way, and only the Lizard's arm can fit through. They look back as the monster yells in utter fury, and they wonder why this is so personal to them. What they didn't know was the one clue they accidently gave away.

They're in relief from escaping, but their lungs are burning from no air. Now all that is left is to escape the sewers and patch themself up. They need to breathe (they're sure as hell not about to drink sewer water, it's bad enough being completely submerged in it), but the current of the water is too strong for them to go back to the surface, but their prayers are answered as they fly out the sewer and onto a shallow patch of water, yet they don't focus on anything else part from laying their and gasping for air, quite happy to ignore their bleeding chest for the time being.

Due to being Spider-Man, they have a well kept stock of medical supplies. Once in the comfort and safety of their home, they pull off their suit and mask, wiping alcohol to disinfect their wounds. They are quite deep and the edges far apart, so after cleaning, they pull the sides of the wounds together and stick them with Steri-Strips before sticking a few adhesive gauze patches to soak up any blood or serous fluid. They miss Adora, but things were

still delicate with her. They were talking, so that was something. They collapse on their bed after, before deciding to scroll through social media on their phone. However, a text message from a certain someone garners their attention. Smiling at the pixelated image of a celebratory bottle of champagne, they text back to ask how soon they can get to Oscorp after they figure out what the Lizard is planning. It means another trip to the sewer, and they can only pray to the high heavens that the creature isn't present when they decide to stop by. With the partnership under their belt, they can sleep easy, and in the morning, perhaps the afternoon, they will meet with Felicia Hardy, as per the agreement.

Yet right now, they only wanted one person in particular - their own attempt at trying to care for their horrendous wounds failing.

Adora arrives at their apartment in record time: five minutes, but not that Catra was counting. She’s equipped with a first aid box, and directs Catra to the bed. Any other time, they would have welcomed this as a roleplay.

Catra can only hiss, sucking the air through their teeth as Adora removes Catra’s own patchwork attempt that was already soaked through with blood. Adora does the same as Catra, but better, more efficient. She manages to close the wounds completely with a lot of those adhesive strips, so many that Catra’s chest was just three conga lines of little white strips, until Adora carefully presses gauze patches to soak up any fluid that may leak. Catra flops back

onto their bed, breathing heavily from not having anything to dull the pain, but breathing heavily causes pain to explode across their chest, so they result to barely breathing at all if that was the sort of pain they would be in.

Adora watches them, tells them to take a nap while she prepares dinner, and leaves to go to the kitchen. An hour later, they're sitting at the kitchen table, eating macaroni cheese. Catra devours it, not realising how hungry they were beforehand. "Oh my God, that was so good," they lean back in their chair. Adora laughs.

Catra misses hearing that sound, misses being the cause of it.

But they were also the cause of something else - something far worse. "Adora," they say with urgency as they sit up straight. "I think I've fucked up really badly."

Adora looks at them.

"You know the lizard creature who attacked today? I might have caused that."

“I don’t understand,” Adora looks as confused as she sounds.

“I gave the equation to Curt Connors so he could regenerate his lost arm. I don’t know if it went wrong or if he did something to it instead, but that’s him. He’s the Lizard.”

“It’s not your fault.” Adora is choosing her words carefully, they can tell. “Obviously, he must have tampered with it, there’s no way your maths could be incorrect. You were just trying to help an old friend of your mother’s.”

“I’m the only one who can stop him.”

“Let me help,” Adora takes their hand.

“No… I’m not letting you risk your life,” they pause. “I’ve asked Felicia.”

Adora frowns, and Catra is prepared for her to shout, release her anger, even storm off, but she doesn’t. She stays, sighs and says: “I guess that’s better. She knows what she’s doing. And she’s not me.”

“That doesn’t mean I want her to die. If she is in trouble tomorrow, I will save her, but she’s trained. She knows how to fight and look after herself. I don’t want you getting into a situation like that, you wouldn’t be able to stall until I arrived. I’m thinking of you. I want you to be safe, Adora. I can’t lose you.”

“You can’t lose me, but you also *can’t* be with me.”

“It’s to keep you safe!”

“We go through this every time, Catra. Let me help. Or train me to fight. It hurts me to see you alone. You have no one to talk to about this, except her or me, and she’s your ex. She’s beautiful, she knows how to seduce someone. I’m not that happy that you’re working with her. But I love *you* , I don’t love Spider-Man.”

Catra sighs. “I’ll train you to fight, if I stop Connors. I promise. We can be together, for real this time.”

The following day, they are sitting on the edge of the roof of an apartment block with Black Cat, discussing Curt Connors and the Lizard. Felicia says they should sneak into Oscorp to find any proof of his plans, and while it may work to see how he became the Lizard, it wouldn't help them find out his true motive and plan. They have to find the Lizard's base of operations, not Dr Curt Connors'.

"You're so smart," Felicia says in her usual sultry tone.

Catra sighs, a smile under the mask forming, but they can't help it. "So, should we go together, or should you go to Oscorp while I go into the sewers again?"

"How will we know where he is?"

"We won't. I trust if you find what went wrong, you can make an antidote."

"I'll see what I can do," she muses, "but I'll send you pictures so you can help with that part."

"Why? Has the Black Cat lost her confidence?" they tease as she playfully shoves them.

"Not at all! You gave him the missing piece, you've been to the lab, know what his research is. All I'm saying is that you'll be of help to me as I've not been in that specific part of Oscorp."

"What part did you steal from, then?" Catra smirks.

"That's something for me to know, and you to find out," she taps her index finger against the side of her nose. "A thief never tells, remember?"

"Really? You just told me," they joke.

"Ah, but I didn't tell you what I stole, or how much."

"Fair play," they shrug.

"So, when should we do this?" Catra changes the subject back.

"I feel like you will say 'as soon as possible', so I'll say, we should probably start as soon as possible."

"Yeah... we probably should," they sigh.

"What's wrong, Spider?" she asks, and Catra mentally curses at themself for being so readable to her.

"I gave him the equation. It's my fault, isn't it?"

"Well, something must have gone wrong, you didn't know the full extent of what he did. It's not your fault. It's his. Maybe he forgot to perfect the serum, or gave himself too big of a dose."

"Maybe," they say quietly, more or less to themself, as they feel better about the situation now. They couldn't have known everything about his project, they only knew the basics, and they just tried to help, so it really wasn't their fault at all. With that in mind, they kick off from the building, and Felicia soon follows, using her grappling hook to swing behind Spider-Man, and try to keep up with him.

After making sure that Felicia has successfully sneaked into Oscorp, there is no doubt that the police will really be after Spider-Man now for working with Black Cat. Still, there's nothing anyone can do, and Spider-Man is walking in the sewers again,

where they find the Lizard to be nowhere in sight, and his base of operations. Computer, a camera for recording, papers and blue prints scattered across a table, and Spider-Man thinks: 'All of this in a sewer, really?' before clicking the 'play' button on the video. Dr Connors explains that he will up the dosage of the serum, and Catra notices that his right arm has not regenerated, and as soon as he injects all the green liquid, he knocks the camera over, and that is where the video ends.

They take pictures of the sheets of papers laying around, and send them to their partner in all of this before finding their way out of the sewers again. They burst out the sewer, never so happy to be breathing fresh, clean air again, but they really need to wash their suit, the $15 cologne they spritzed all over it can only do so much to mask the blindingly obvious scent of sewer.

Felicia texts back with pictures, and Spider-Man views the images while swinging, attempting to text back by saying the Lizard will turn everyone in the city into creatures like him. Felicia writes back saying that he is climbing up Oscorp. "Shit!" Catra puts their phone away, and changes their course to the Oscorp Tower.

Firing a web, they don't take hold of it, instead twisting their body mid-air before shooting a web in the opposite direction to dodge a bullet from a specialised taser gun, and it looks like getting to Oscorp will be more of a challenge than previously thought now that the police have tracked them down. There's so many bullets being fired at them, they get hit in the sternum and fall, dead weight, onto the bonnet of a police car.

Officers move in closer to a seemingly unconscious Spider-Man, and carefully handcuff him, and pull him into the road (blocked off

by various police cars). One officer in particular steps into the mix, pulling off the mask of the vigilante. As soon as the mask comes off, Spider-Man breaks free of the hand cuffs and moves out of the helicopter spot-light, they fire webbing simultaneously at two officers' faces, and knock out three more, and that's when they freeze again, turning to look at the man who now held them at gun point. "Dad..."

"Catra..."

"You have to let me go," they slowly edge forward to bend down so they can pick up their mask, and put it back on. Their father nods, his gun pointing to ground now, telling them to go.

"Hold your fire!" he orders his officers, but one doesn't listen, and a bullet penetrates Catra's leg.

At her brother’s apartment, Adora stares at the television screen, a live broadcast of Spider-Man trying to get to Oscorp Tower, but they're struggling to climb up a building after being shot in the leg. Adora makes a mental note to try and get Catra to go to a

proper doctor, because she knows she won't be able to remove the bullet, not when Catra only has vodka as their numbing agent, but it all depends if Catra even wants her support in the first place; their relationship is still a sensitive topic, no matter what they agreed earlier. She watches as they make it to the top of the building, a helicopter search light shining down on them as they patch up the wound with a web. The light moves from Spider-Man to cranes ahead, cranes that will help Spider-Man swing to the tower.

Adora's heart is lodged in her throat as Spider-Man staggers into a run, leaping off the building while shooting a web. The web misses the first crane, and they plummet. Adora clamps a hand over her mouth to stop a sudden yelp from being voiced, and Bow looks over at her. Luckily, Adora can simmer it all down to the fact that she doesn't like violence or people being hurt and trying to press on. If not, she would be stuck, and her brother would only suspect something was going on between her and Spider-Man -- it's a funny thought, really.

Clinging to a metal bar that is normally used for construction, Spider-Man climbs to the top side of it, looking to the person in charge of this crane, which has just saved them and this city, because if they hadn't swooped in and caught them, by the time Spider-Man reached Oscorp, the Lizard would have won and this city would be in ruins. They stand up before shooting a web to the next crane along, swinging with the help of the construction site workers. The police stop traffic so Spider-Man can swing past safely, and try to get to Oscorp as fast as possible.

Meanwhile, on the ground, Felicia has been stopped by Catra's father. "You need to get this to Spider-Man!" she says, holding out the antidote, a bright blue chemical inside that Spider-Man can use to turn the Lizard back to Dr Curt Connors.

He agrees, telling her to get out of here before he changes his mind about letting the Black Cat go.

The Lizard stands at the very top of the Oscorp Tower, metal mesh for floor, and there's not room for two. The machine tells him that his device will detonate in two minutes, and everyone who is still in the city will end up like him. Spider-Man swoops down, swinging around and kicking him off his perch, yet he grabs their foot, and there's brief blows traded before they crash onto the roof of the tower, narrowly avoiding some satellite dishes that would do substantial damage if one was impaled by them. Spider-Man jumps out of the way, barely dodging the Lizard's arm as it goes to grab them. They try to swing away, but the Lizard grabs their leg and tosses them off the side of the sky scraper. They fire a web after minorly panicking about what damage a fall from this height would do, they've never realised how tall Oscorp is. Crawling up the building, they return to the fight, dodging the Lizard trying to hit them with a barrel of liquid nitrogen. They fire a web at his face and laugh as it works, he disappears from sight, as Spider-Man still hasn't managed to get back on the roof, still on the edge of the building. A second later, the webbing is gone from his face, and Catra sighs; it was too good to be true. They swing and hit the Lizard with both feet in his abdomen, but it does very

little to him. Spider-Man dodges several more attacks before swinging to the cylindrical metal feature, but another barrel of liquid nitrogen heading their way makes them abandon that plan of action. They fall back to the roof, but they can see that the chemical hissing out the break in the container is freezing the metal.

For some reason, the roof of Oscorp has a ton of liquid nitrogen stored up here. Spider-Man tries to reach for a container, but the Lizard forces them to the ground, his tail wrapping around their throat, pulling him up to his height, and it's only at this point, that Spider-Man realises how tall the Lizard is as well. Both hands squeeze the wrists of them, destroying both of Spider-Man's web shooters. "Do you have any idea how hard these are to make?!" they complain, but he couldn't care less about such things. As routine, the Lizard takes off their mask.

"Poor Catra... No mother, no father, all alone."

"I thought you were going to list things," Catra chokes out, and he only increases the pressure, but they wonder how he knows their name. The only thing they can think of is their phone background being a photo of them with Adora.

"No chance of winning."

"We'll see about that. By the way, you're wrong. I do have a father," they smirk a little as a gun cocking can be heard.

"And she's not alone," their father says. Catra is just thankful that help has arrived, never mind being referred to with female pronouns. Still, they are going by the name Spider-Man, isn't that enough of a clue?

He fires a bullet at a flexible pipe flowing to the liquid nitrogen, and the pipe hisses and squirms, and Catra manages to grab hold of it and begin freezing the Lizard's face and tail, releasing the pressure from their almost crushed trachea. Now standing on the ground, they use two hands to continue attacking the Lizard with their new found weapon. The tip of their tail breaks off, but it hasn't done much else, so Catra's father fires bullets at the Lizard, until Spider-Man kicks the Lizard into the pool of liquid nitrogen. While their father continues to attack the Lizard with bullets, and open some more containers, the computer alerts them that there is 45 seconds until detonation. "This is from Black Cat," he hands Catra the antidote, and they begin to climb up to the computer to replace the Lizard's serum with the antidote. Catra is too busy concentrating against the timer to realise that the Lizard has come out of the ditch full of what didn't prove to be the best weapon anymore, and sink his claws into the chest of their father.

They pull open the capsule, and take out the Lizard's one -- who is currently racing up to stop Spider-Man -- while the computer begins the countdown from ten. Catra shoves the antidote in, and not a second later does the Lizard grab their leg again, but he stops when they both watch the projectile launch, Spider-Man hanging onto the metal slat surface with one arm. The projectile explodes, the sky covered by blue vapours.

And the scales of the Lizard begin to crack, and he falls down to the concrete roof of the Oscorp Tower. The metal spike starts to collapse, and with no web shooters, Spider-Man has no choice but to sit on top and pray as they begin to fall. They decide to jump at the last few seconds, and they slide to the very edge of the roof, then over the side of the building, one hand gripping to the roof as they take in the situation, watching as the metal pole falls to the ground below. Only then do they look up to see what is putting pressure on their wrist.

Dr Curt Connors pulls Catra back onto the roof, his right arm slowly disintegrating. They sit together for a few minutes, not saying anything. Catra searches for their mask when the police arrive.

Catra sighs, having finally finalised the sale of their father's house. They didn't bother with a funeral, too much money, but Adora and her family, and a few work colleagues came round for drinks. It was nice enough, and after everything, they realise they miss

Adora, so they invite her over to their apartment. They agree that it's just an evening spent together, yet Adora spends the night too. And then the following day.

Living alone, although they are very used to it, it can get boring, so they decide to have more of an easier approach to a roommate. Well, it goes without saying that Catra can't risk having another actual human living with them, so they are left with a few decisions.

Walking along the high street, they enter a specific shop. "I'd like to buy a pet mouse, please."

And Adora screams when she sees what Catra had brought home.

the rhino

Sometimes, there's not much to do for the friendly neighbourhood Spider-Man, so wandering aimlessly is a big chunk of their daily/nightly patrols (that's what they have decided to call them), but every so often, a villain only they can defeat appears. This time, it is a very large muscular... man in a metal suit. While he hasn't attacked anything yet, he is an eye sore to say the least, leading to Spider-Man, as well as the media, giving him the rather kind nickname of 'Rhino', and he absolutely hates it. According to records, his real name is Aleksei Sytsevich, and as luck would have it, Spider-Man is his target, who was so bored currently, learning a new language was on the agenda. Due to Rhino, they have decided to learn Russian in preparation for what native words he may call the wall-crawler, as it's common for people who learnt English as a second language, often swear or mutter things in their mother tongue, Catra has seen it with their neighbours in their apartment complex.

They decide to learn some basic words and sentences, and then some words that could be used as insults alone, and what 'spider' is in Russian, to be sure. They make sure to learn words appropriate for Spider-Man, like 'to fight' and a few of their own quips translated. Apart from that, they researched Aleksei Sytsevich, a former member of a Russian mob as an enforcer, his powers from a massive Rhino themed suit that he can't remove, and Catra laughs at that. How stupid... is what they would say, if they hadn't realised that they probably spend more time in the Spider-Man suit than out of it. Still, Rhino will prove to be a troublesome opponent -- he is *massive* , and he could wipe the floor with Spider-Man if they aren't careful. There's no real logical solution that Catra can think of to aid in his defeat. Maybe dropping large, heavy, shipping containers or something like that, but the only problem is luring him near the coast, where the

docks are located. It seems impossible, that the only way they can think of defeating him is by causing traumatic head injuries. It's severely weaken him to keep him down for good, or fully knock him out long enough for the police to take him to the Raft. His suit must increase his strength tenfold, as well as durability, while Spider-Man is just a person in spandex with web shooters. Their suit doesn't offer much protection, it is just a recognisable symbol of hope for the people of New York.

Still, they have done a lot of work for one villain. One might say too much, or not to have bothered at all. Fighting could get repetitive and boring at times, they wanted to freshen things up, and learning Russian to taunt their opponent was definitely one way to go about it. There's been a couple of new things happening in their life recently.

A new side job, they attach a camera to a wall with webs, and set the camera on a timer, taking pictures of Spider-Man that are sent to the Daily Bugle. It's almost as good a pay per photo as one day working as a mechanic. The owner of the newspaper company is J. Jonah Jameson, who some may describe as aggressive, others passionate. To Catra, it doesn't matter to much because he is paying them a stupid amount of money for their photos of Spider-Man, and they say that because he absolutely *despises* the vigilante. He relishes in anything that may hurt Spider-Man's reputation, to defame the hero.

They sigh as they place the new set of photos into an envelope for when they drop by the Daily Bugle building later today. They still work as a mechanic, well, they try to, because crimes do not happen when they have the allocated time to be preventing petty little crimes, so they're late for work a lot. It's lucky their boss likes them, but even he is getting fed up with his employee's pure lack of punctuality. One of these days, Catra will snap under pressure and blurt out that they are Spider-Man, and that's why they are often late for work, not because they don't care about their job.

Slipping on their denim jacket, they say 'goodbye' to Jerry (their pet mouse), before leaving their apartment. Adora had already left for work at least an hour before them. For once, they believe that they can make it to work without a Spider-Man level threat happening in this damn city. For once, let something good happen in Catra's life, not Spider-Man's (as they have decided Spider-Man loves fighting, some sort of coping mechanism). The public just see Spider-Man for who he is, not too bothered about their civilian identity now. Just a guy from Queens with extraordinary powers, one media outlet has put it as. It panics Catra, who wonders how on Earth the company knew their hometown, but then again, they are very chatty while fighting, and often forget there will always be some helicopter with a desperate reporter giving a live commentary of fights, particularly fights with lives on the line if Spider-Man doesn't stop the attacker, not so much Spider-Man stopping muggings or break-ins. They wouldn't make for good news coverage as they are a daily occurrence in the day to day life of the web slinger. Oh boy... the names the media give Spider-Man never fails to amuse Catra. A common favourite among villains is 'web head', and that is just one of the family friendly ones.

They hear police sirens (as if on cue somehow), and they groan in annoyance, taking their mask out their pocket and putting it on. They are so thankful everyone else is dead to the world at this hour, as they begin to swing in the direction of the sirens while their spidey-sense grows stronger, a feeling they believe they will never get used to. They land on the roof with elegance, shove their clothes into their backpack before jumping to the action. There's not a moment that goes by where the suit isn't on under their clothes. It's like a second skin by this point.

They swoop down and catch a car from crushing a mother and her two children. They forget how weird this must look, a person holding a car up like it's nothing at all. They put the car back on it's four wheels before looking for who threw it. "Hey, buddy, pick on someone your own size!" they call out.

"There is no one my own size!" a voice with a Russian accent answers.

"Ah, my mistake," they laugh as they swing over to Rhino. “I mistook you for a scrap heap.”

"Глупый мальчик!" their opponent yells in frustration.

"Я просто человек!" Catra shouts back. They might be a stupid person, but not a stupid boy.

"Человек?"

Catra retreats and sits on top of a lamp post, remembering that this is a fight between *Spider-Man* and Rhino, not who Spider-Man really is. After taking a moment, they correct themself, saying they were neither boy nor girl, but a man. They jump off the post and a swinging kick manages to knock their opponent down to the ground, cracking the tarmac of the road in the process. Police have started to evacuate the area, and now they just have to focus on buying enough time to complete the evacuation.

"Дурак!" Rhino goes to tackle them, but they back-flip out of the way.

"Could you maybe tone it down with the insults? They're really cutting deep," they fake a sob before pulling a manhole cover out

the ground with a web, and smacking him over the head with it. Being called a fool wasn’t exactly harsh, but they would be lying if they said they didn’t enjoy toying with their opponent. "Do you understand?" they inquire before going back up to the lamp post, waiting to see if he moves.

"I am still better than you, паук," Rhino says after a minute or two, allowing Spider-Man some time to check all civilians are out of the area. Calling him Spider only reminded him of Felicia.

"Really? Then why are you the one on the ground?" Come on, Rhino, you can do better!"

He demands that they fight again, recovering from the blow.

"Again?" they blurt out. They didn't really want to fight again, but what was new there? Opponents just won't stay down, and as long as that is the case, neither will they.

"You don't want to?"

"I'm always up for fighting, just I'm in a hurry!"

"Don't worry, I will make easy work of you."

"Ah, you're too kind," they say as they swiftly dodge an attack. It occurs to them that this will turn into a chase, and they welcome it as if they can tire him out by not actually having to waste their own energy, it will be the easiest win ever.

They begin swinging from building to building, and Rhino soon follows. They're nearing the Daily Bugle building, and there's enough time for a quick stop, so they do.

"Special delivery," Spider-Man taps on the window of J. Jonah Jameson's office, slipping the envelope through and disappearing as soon as they appear. They don't know how long it will be until Catra can collect the money, probably a while as they're yet to weaken their opponent, who is surprisingly fast in that clunky costume.

They sharply turn a corner, and they regret that move as Rhino barrels into a block of apartments, unable to turn into the street with such momentum and the heavy weight of the suit. "Shit!" they use a lamp post to do an even quicker u-turn and pray they are still in an area where the police have ordered an evacuation. Luckily, it was, and it has now given them a new weapon.

They fire a line of webbing at some rubble and swing it at their opponent. "That was a good idea of yours," they comment as the next phase of the fight consists of Spider-Man dodging debris thrown at them, only to use their web shooters to throw it back at Rhino, who is unable to dodge due to his size.

A few good hits land on Rhino's unprotected face, yet he has the realisation that he is able to grab onto the incoming projectile and yank Spider-Man towards him before they can even react. His armoured arms are crushing Spider-Man's body into the jagged metal of his chest plate.

"You hug with such passion," they manage to say. In the end, they just go limp as they really have no idea how to escape this. They wiggle their arms a little, enough to get them in an appropriate position. There's only one chance at this attack. They are able to move their fingers, and they deduce that Rhino can't feel their movements through his suit, so it's perfect.

They pull both their middle fingers and ring fingers back to their palms to trigger their web shooters, that fire webs to the road. As soon as the webs latch on to the ground, they use their strength and body weight to pull down, in conjunction with their web shooters rapidly recoiling the released webbing back into the shooters in under a second, and Rhino's grip is lost as he is flipped over onto his back in an odd kind of suplex.

The impact sends deep cracks up the road, and it knocks the energy out of both of them. It's a draw.

The fight with Rhino, destroying several city blocks by the end of it, left Catra needing a couple of weeks to recover from it, certain a few bones were broken, of which Adora couldn't do much. With the recovery period, they remember something that may be of help to them.

Black Cat has a renowned ability to give bad luck to those in her line of sight. It's almost unfair, but it's the only way that Catra can think of to have an actual chance of defeating Rhino without defeating their own body in the process. They roll their shoulder as they give Jerry some fresh food and water, and sit on the counter, eating their own breakfast with him. The apartment is open plan for the kitchen and living room, and the mouse tank is kept on a sturdy, old table in the living room near where the

kitchen joins on. They like their apartment as it is very generous for the price they paid for it. Anyway, the apartment isn't the important thing here, as once again, Spider-Man saving New York is the topic at hand, and Catra's own life is put on hold until the threat is dealt with... until a new -- probably stronger -- threat appears on the streets, with a new -- probably stronger -- pulsing hatred of Spider-Man.

Felicia is the only 'good' person-similar-to-them that they can trust and work with. Simply put, she's the only one who won't use her powers against Spider-Man... or so Catra hopes that is the case. They've been through a lot together, and the media love writing articles and sparking rumours about them. They've learnt to ignore it. Part of their heart still hurt from Felicia's actions towards them, yet she is the only one who is able to help them in battle. She is purely interested in Spider-Man, not Catra. The only exception would be when they were both drunk, although Catra was sure she got off on the fact she was the only person in the world to say (and could say) that she was dating Spider-Man. There's no doubt lots of people who would die to say those words in a sentence, and have it be true, and Catra didn't know how to feel about that exactly.

Perhaps it is a nice thought that people feel so passionately about Spider-Man. Like Felicia does, or used to. Catra doesn't know what she thinks of Spider-Man anymore, but they assume it's the former. They frown as they slather more butter onto the perfectly toasted bread, tossing the knife in the general direction of the kitchen sink, hearing it make quite a noise as it lands. Rhino could attack today, tomorrow, the day after tomorrow, maybe sometime next week, and how ever soon the ever looming battle may be, it

was one that Catra wasn't sure they could win. They were stuck. If they failed, there is no saying that Rhino would stop after killing Spider-Man, and kill innocent lives. No, no, no. Failure is not an option here, they *have* to win this. There is no question about that.

The washing machine quiets down before beeping to announce that the current wash load is finished, and Catra hops off the counter and goes to attend to the washing. They open the door and pull out the Spider-Man suit before hanging it on the clothes horse to dry. Nothing better go wrong for at least two hours, because by that time, the suit will be fully dry. They can't go out into public in a damp Spider-Man suit, that's for sure.

Catra watches Jerry eat his rodent mix for a few minutes, smiling at how cute he is, before sitting on the sofa and switching the TV on to pass the time while Adora breaks the record for the longest shower. Ever since she moved in, the water bill had skyrocketed. They enter the buttons of the news channel to view the headlines, the remote in their left hand, and their phone in their right, as they send Felicia a text message. Dropping their phone beside them on the sofa, they watch the news reporter reporting from the site of the fight two weeks ago, confirming that road works are in place to fix the surface, further implied by the road roller in the background, but typical of builders, it isn't doing anything and no construction workers are in sight. The reporter goes on to question Rhino, and a broadcast of the fight -- of course someone recorded the fucking fight, someone *always* does -- is playing as the reporter talks about Rhino's ability. It's clear they don't know what they are talking about. No one ever does when it comes to these types of reports, because it's almost unbelievable. In fact,

Catra is positive that not one of the reporters believes a word of what they say when it comes to Spider-Man and his numerous villains. They never expected to report on such topics, nor did they seem to want to, but it was very good coverage as it will tune in more viewers, and make children and teenagers want to watch the news in case new video clips of Spider-Man are shown.

That reminds them. They have to drop in to the Daily Bugle to pick up their owed money for the Spider-Man pictures. Can they risk it? Just once without the suit? They decide to. They decide to be really quick about it as well, and they are lucky that they don't live far away from the newspaper's publishing block. Switching off the television set, and grab their denim jacket and head out the door.

Like most young people, Catra is on their phone while walking, so that they almost walk past their destination. They go to J. Jonah Jameson's office and knock on the door.

"You finally show up!" he turns around in his chair, cigar in his mouth. "You'll never guess what," Catra opens their mouth to answer, but he continues the moment he sees it happen. "Either you have some explaining to do, or Spider-Man delivered his own pictures!"

"Oh, he did it as a favour. I was busy."

"A favour? He's doing people *favours* now, is he? Look, I don't pay Spider-Man, I pay *you* . Hand in your own photos like expected, or I see no reason to pay you. I might as well pay Spider-Man!" He doesn't talk normally, either talking very loudly (and very angrily), or shouting, and there is a fine line between the two.

"Sorry, sir," they finally get a chance to speak. He slaps an envelope on the desk.

"Now, take it before I change my mind!"

Catra does as told and leaves the building before peeking into the envelope to see it's contents. *Money.* They sigh in relief. They were sure that J. Jonah Jameson, deep down (very deep down), actually likes Spider-Man, even if he would rather be caught dead than admitting it. He means well. He cares, somewhere in his heart. Placing the envelope in their pocket, they take their phone out when a sudden bleep accompanied by a vibration alerts them to a new text message.

Unlocking their phone, they read the text from Felicia, and quickly type out a reply. Now all that is left to do is to wait for Rhino to attack somewhere to gain Spider-Man's attention. They go back home, not wanting (or liking) to be outside without wearing the suit underneath their regular clothes, and take Jerry out of his cage and let him run around the floor, although he seems to like it best when he just has to sit on top of Spider-Bot, and Catra controls where he goes, because they don't exactly like it when he gets to roam freely in case he goes behind the sofa or washing machine.

They smile as they hold the control pad for Spider-Bot in their hand as the mouse on top appears to be quite happy having a ride. Still, almost an hour later, their time to play is over as the TV in the background broadcasts a breaking news story of Rhino attacking the streets of New York City before being cut off by Adora switching the hairdryer on. They scoop up the small rodent in their hands and gently place him back in his cage, making sure that it is secure. Their clothes are removed and thrown carelessly in multiple directions, wearing just a pair of black underwear underneath the suit. They open the back window of their apartment and climb out of it, before heading to the scene of the action.

"Didn't you have enough last time?" Spider-Man quips as they crouch on top of a lamp post as Rhino charges at them. They jump as he pulls the lamp post out of the ground and twirls it around like a circus baton. Catra isn't one hundred percent sure what exactly he plans to do with that, but knocking bricks out of

buildings probably should have been higher up on their list. One person is missing from this battle, and that is Black Cat. She should be here by now! She lives closer to this area than they do. Even if her grappling hook swings slower than Spider-Man's webs, she should still be here by now. They're really not sure if they can do this on their own. Last time they went into combat on their own against Rhino, a considerable amount of property was destroyed, and it took *two* weeks for them to finally feel better, and through those two weeks, they still had to stop little crimes. They should stop feeling sorry for themself, they know, but they're on their own in both lives that they lead. No one can understand what it is like to be Spider-Man. It's impossible to imagine doing such feats that Spider-Man does, effortlessly, on the daily.

"I was going to say the same to you!" Rhino answers.

"Well, no. You started this fight, not me. You practically called me out to this rather remote location, if I may say. Is this where you live?"

That strikes a nerve, as the lamp post is thrown like a javelin at them. They dodge automatically thanks to their spidey-sense, and stifle a chuckle. "Is that the best you have?" It's really not the best idea to provoke him any more, especially not when he is already enraged, but the damage is already done.

Provoking people is what Spider-Man does best, second to putting bad guys behind bars, that is. Just the mere existence of him enrages many people. Although most probably wouldn't engage him in a battle because he would make such easy work of them it would be laughable. Anger fuels most of Spider-Man's enemies, and he doesn't understand why. He's adorable. People have even made merch of him.

They dodge, flipping onto Rhino's shoulders, a move they didn't know where to take next. A line of webbing is released, and they hold it with both hands as they place it over his throat and pull it back against it. It pulls his neck back a little, but with how strong Spider-Man is pulling (and probably because of the bulky, metallic suit that is protecting Rhino), the web snaps in half, and they fall back onto the ground. Before they can process what just happened, and why in God’s name they thought that would be a good idea, a sudden weight on their torso -- a very *heavy* weight -- knocks their breath out of their lungs. Their vision is blurry as all they can do is sit and take it, lay and pray that it soon ends. They don't know how much more of this they can physically take, and more and more pressure is slowly applied. Suddenly, it is all taken off, but it is all returned by the time they realise there is nothing weighing them down, but the pain of every ounce still stays.

'Where the fuck is Felicia?' is the only thing they can think of as they struggle for air as Rhino continues to crush their chest under his foot, except it isn't *just* his foot now, he lifts his other foot off the ground so Spider-Man's small body (compared to his) takes his entire body weight. There's definite cracks of bones given in

under such pressure, and they genuinely think that this is the end of Spider-Man now, so beneath the mask, they close their eyes. They feel themself begin to drift in and out of consciousness, so they really assume the worst now. Suddenly, their prayers are answered when a trademark smoke bomb rolls out and hits Spider-Man's arm. Smoke clouds the area, Rhino's other foot is on the ground, they can tell because pressure is lifted off. There's enough weight released that they are able to use their web shooters to pull them far away, out of the smoke and into clear air, and they climb a little way up a building, and Felicia joins the battle.

"Sorry, Spider. I got caught up in.. something."

"Did that 'something' happen to be theft?"

"It's not theft," she shrugs. "I'm simply taking from the rich, and giving to the poor."

"Yeah, well, right now we have better things to be doing!" they argue, although they're trying not to make a scene, not to start

another fight, right now. This can be saved for later. It's not important, and the main thing is that Felicia is here now.

"That's not the first time you said that, although maybe it *is* a first in a battle."

They groan, hand holding their head at their former partner, both romantically and on the more legal side of the law. "Let's just *try* and defeat him."

Felicia just nods, throwing another smoke bomb in Rhino's direction, before the duo use the cover of the smoke to their advantage as they land a couple of good hits in on their opponent. Well, it's all Spider-Man's doing really. All Felicia does is throw EMPs and smoke bombs. It's helpful, definitely, but is it going to physically weaken the opposition?

Catra can't help but laugh as the Black Cat's bad luck begins to take effect, as Rhino trips over and falls flat on his face, allowing them both to attack... is what Catra expects, but Felicia holds her hands up, saying she won't be much use to an opponent in such a hefty suit. They sigh, and go ahead with their own attacks; webs and swinging whatever they could get hold of, like car doors and man-hole covers. It's almost going too well, until the moment

their spider-sense fails, they somehow hit themself with a man-hole cover due to it, and their web shooters stop working. It then occurs to Catra that Black Cat's bad luck ability affects anyone in her vicinity if she panics, or maybe she is just staring at them. "What the fuck?" they shout over to her, as Rhino comes back around, and they have no time to react as their ankles are seized, and they are slammed into the road. Debris flies and dust bellows from the impact. Spider-Man groans and they take a second to let the pain sink in before slowly rolling over, leaning on their left forearm as their right hand pushes up so they can sit up.

They regain their senses, discover their powers and web shooters work again, and they can only hope that Felicia hasn't left the fight altogether. "Move out the way!" her voice warns, and Catra scrambles to their feet and fire a line of webbing over to a wall. Felicia follows suit, and they are about to ask why she said that, until a speeding lorry sends Rhino flying a good three hundred metres.

"Is he... down?" Catra asks as they both look down the street.

"I think so?" Felicia replies, squinting.

They swing over, perching on the balcony of a block of apartments where Rhino lays in the street, unconscious and defeated. Sirens are heard, and police cars and a specialised van arrive on the scene. Felicia runs a hand through her hair as she looks at herself in the reflection of the glass door. Catra grabs her arm as they jump into a swing onto the next building, shorter, so they stand on the roof. Catra half-expected her to pull out a pocket mirror now.

"Пока-пока, Rhino!" they grin under the mask as they wave their farewell. "The Raft will have a tough time with him," they say to Felicia.

"Yeah, well, it's where he belongs," she answers as both of them watch Rhino being hauled into the Raft's transportation van for new arrivals. Once the van doors are locked, they both take their leave, Felicia no doubt going on a celebratory robbery as Catra orders a celebratory pizza to devour with Adora.

the scorpion

A private investigator has been hired by J. Jonah Jameson, who wants to know how Catra is able to take such incredible photos of Spider-Man. It seems easy enough to a skilled detective like Mac Gargan, so he thinks little of it as he wanders around the streets of New York, attempting to locate the photographer. Except he can't find them anywhere. Every time that he thinks he sees them, he quickly prepares his camera and arms himself with his little notepad and pencil, but when he looks back up afterwards, they have vanished. It's frustrating, but more frustrating to his employer, and no one wants to have J. Jonah Jameson screaming at their face for *so* long.

One last chance he is allowed, and he is determined to find their target this time. He sees them, average height, short brown hair, denim jacket and a backpack, presumably walking to work. He is following them at a safe, not stalker-ish, distance. They turn off into a side street, he is in the same street ten seconds later, and he looks down it. Nothing. Absolutely nothing. They've vanished into thin air again, and he throws his notepad down in anger.

He returns to the Daily Bugle building, and the middle-aged man offers to make him able to find Catra. He agrees, not knowing what exactly he is agreeing to. It's shifty. God, it's fucking dodgy, but he's in a bad spot anyway. What can get any worse? He takes it, and... it's like nothing he has ever been through. It's borderline torture. This can't be legal, but he signed a contract; he can't complain or sue. He can't do anything. He has to let it happen. He has to let it happen if he wants to get to the bottom of this

photographer's deal with Spider-Man. And, he *really* does want to. The mere thought of that seemingly master-evader of a photographer makes his blood boil.

He's lead down a dull corridor, (a dim, flickering light only adding to his suspicion) by the doctor in charge of this experiment. The building itself is rundown, almost falling apart, but they go downstairs to the basement, and it's only a mild improvement from the ground floor. Parts of the ceiling tiles are coming away from the ceiling, and wires poke out from them, and various other gaps in the walls (and even the floor).

At the end of the long, narrow corridor is a heavy, metal door. The man unlocks it, pushes it open, and waits for the man to follow him inside. Reluctance is the word to describe his major second thoughts.

A deep breath in is his only comfort, and he steps forward. The door slams shut, and the vibration is carried through the floor, and before he can process everything in the room, two people grab hold of him. He yells. It's no use. He struggles, they slam him against solid metal.

Mac is strapped down on a cold, solid, metal table after his shirt is removed. He squirms and struggles against the thick leather belts chaffing his skin as they keep him pinned down, various leads stick to his body, connecting him to various machines. The man is a doctor, well, he assumes he is a doctor, as he comes over to him with a large syringe filled with a suspicious dark green concoction. The second person in the room, he assumes is his assistant, and he is holding onto a notepad, his pen poised. He clicks the top, writing down his observations.

GARGAN, Mac. Male. 20. The Scorpion Test Subject.

Specimen showing signs of fear.

Specimen resisting.

Heart rate: 165bpm. Continuing anyway.

He hisses and flinches as the syringe stabs into his bicep, and the liquid enters his system. His arm aches from the puncture, but that's only the first part (that happens with all injections). He feels... funny. He can't describe the feeling, because before he can try and pin point it, he falls unconscious.

Specimen injected with SC#012.

Specimen rendered unconscious. Vitals stabilising.

We can only wait and see if the experiment is a success.

Time of injection: 13:43.

Time of wake: 14:01.

Mac wakes up, suddenly, and he jolts up, easily breaking the straps that he didn't even recall. He doesn't recall being in an operating room at all. His breathing is ragged and heavy, as he stands up, scanning the room. His nostrils flare with each inhale as he turns in a circle. He senses...

a spider.

Out of nowhere. A sixth sense, maybe?

He can barely process what is happening until after he crushes the spider in the palm of his hand. Another door opens in the room, this time lifting up from the bottom. On the other side is a suit. It's scorpion themed, a deep green like what he was injected

with. It was with his measurements, custom made for him, and the most prominent feature is the long tail, with an adept stinger.

He walks towards it.

Specimen angered.

Specimen breaks free.

Specimen showing animalistic instincts.

Experiment success.

Recently, Catra puts their guard up, suspecting a new villain on the horizon. Their spidey-sense has been tingling, and they know it doesn't do that for no reason, so they are quick to vacate the premises before the sensation gets any stronger, where they may be left helpless if they don't have time to become Spider-Man in privacy; or worse, someone knows that they are Spider-Man, and want to make it known to the city that they are Spider-Man.

The first time: they were on a walk for some fresh air and bumped into Adora, who was in the middle of her evening jog, and they join her, telling her they think someone is following them, and after they ran a considerable distance, they turned off their current street and Catra climbed a wall, all the way to the roof of the building.

The second time: Black Cat creates a distraction in general, a complete coincidence, and they take the chance and get into a taxi.

The third time: they go into a very crowded area and lose him.

The fourth time: they turn off into the nearest street and run up the wall to stay out of sight on a roof.

But the fifth time, they are caught off guard, their spidey-sense suddenly went from zero to one hundred, and they turn to see a man in a Scorpion themed suit, demanding to be taken to Spider-Man, and explain how the photos are taken. They're confused, but they start walking, and the man follows.

Catra sighs, telling him to stay, as they enter a block of apartments that they didn't live at, but they know someone who does, and she is kind enough to let Catra leave their clothes and backpack while Spider-Man takes care of the new villain in town. It’s Adora’s apartment that she’s planning to sell soon, so Catra hopes that they won’t regret coming here later, if their opponent was one step ahead. They climb out of the window and swing around to the front of the apartment complex, their spidey-sense warns them of the danger the... Scorpion can cause. Yeah, that's his name now, judging by his suit and all, it certainly fits him, and much easier to figure out the animal theme to his suit than Rhino, who looked like a scrap heap until the media gave him a name, not even Catra could figure that out. A name that builds up so much rage inside him, and the nice thing to do would be to call him 'Aleksei' as it's his name, but where's the fun in that?

They go to attack, but Scorpion does something that only builds up fear inside them.

He dodges before they land a hit.

He knew they were going to attack.

Spider-Man lands on the wall, and stares. There's no explanation they can think of. It's not possible for anyone else to do that, right? Sure, as long as he can't climb up walls.

But they have a plan; run, or rather, swing away, to give them time to think of an attack.

Oh, would you look at that? *He's climbing the walls.*

Catra supposes that his next trick is to do with his tail, much like how Spider-Man has web shooters, it's a guarantee something similar will happen.

Ah, there it is. They were almost beginning to worry that nothing has happened in a while as they race through the city, but blasts of poison, that takes the cake. However, their spidey-sense forces them to automatically dodge, and they believe that's all Scorpion has. They'll have to counterattack sooner or later, they just don't know how. If they swing over the top and attack from behind, he will attack with his own version of spider-sense... scorpy-sense? Spider-Man holds back a laugh as they think of that.

The scorpion is the natural predator of the spider. But not this spider.

They aim their web shooters at his face, and once he can't see, they swing on top of him and fire two lines of webbing to the road below and recoils them to send them both plummeting into the road surface. The impact seems to have shaken up the Scorpion, but Spider-Man wastes no time in restraining his limbs and tail with webs before proceeding to repeatedly punch his face, and maybe they are a little too violent, but it's no secret that they're scared. They are still young, and all these villains keep popping up out of no where.

They were unaware at the time, but fear overrides their spidey-sense, makes it less effective, so much that they will be able to ignore it. Or, maybe fear pushes their senses into override, and it was not effective before it was already at it's peak and overwhelmed by the entire situation.

Either way, they never sensed that Scorpion has freed his tail until it wrapped around their ankle and yanked them upwards, and they were just dangling upside down while Scorpion stands up, proceeds to threaten them, before throwing them with incredible force into a building, and Spider-Man crashes through the three walls because of it.

They have never been so relieved when Scorpion never came after them, but they were quick to come out of the rubble and retreat just in case, forcing themself to keep moving, and not rest.

After the fight, they didn't go home to recuperate, instead they ended up breaking into the publisher of the Daily Bugle's office, and it occurs to Catra that he did this to Gargan, he paid $10,000 on experiments to splice an animal's characteristics with a human's. Reading a diary from a locked drawer (that they just tugged open due to their enhanced strength), they are informed that the experiments went wrong, resulting in Gargan losing his sanity, and the villian known as Scorpion was born. The stronger he got, the more unhinged he became. Dr Farley Stillwell is the man recruited by Jameson after he read an article about inducing animal mutations into a human. They sit in the desk chair, continuing to read. J. Jonah Jameson also paid money for a scorpion themed suit to be manufactured for Gargan, effectively, this is his own creation, he turned some innocent person into his own guinea pig so he could have someone to fight Spider-Man,

and bring him down. It worked, they'll give him that at least. They've received quite a beating, and they were lucky he seemingly became distracted from delivering what they assumed to be some fatal last blows, allowing them to use their web shooters to retreat.

Reading on, he writes that he wants to know how Catra takes such photos of *'that menace, Spider-Man'* and the answer is very simple. Something that hasn't been told is how Catra knew J. Jonah Jameson would give rewards for photos, but that is for another time. They place the diary back in the drawer and proceed to leave the premises by the window, as standard for Spider-Man.

This was an opponent who has been custom-made to kill Spider-Man, and they are capable.

But Spider-Man has something equally powerful against him. His *identity* .

Mac Gargan. Former private investigator. An extreme temper.

Maybe Catra is too confident now, drunk on it. They can't. They have to focus. This is a man who managed to defeat them... easily. They're just angry about it, and they want to put him behind bars as quickly as possible. A private investigator... could it be him who was causing Catra's anxiety about their alter-ego? Was it Mac who was so close to finding them?

They ignore those thoughts for now. They have more important matters to attend to, even though before they can do that, they have a couple of people who need a visit.

Dr Farley Stillwell is first on that list, and they find his address almost too easily, the back of a card in Jameson's desk. It wasn't his home address, likely his lair or something. They really hope so, nothing is as a good as having a good snoop around a mad man's lair. It's almost their favourite part of being Spider-Man, but the number one spot goes to being able to swing through New York. It's truly amazing being able to swing from sky scraper to sky scraper.

It's an abandoned building, almost falling apart. They're scared to step too heavily in case it all comes tumbling down. They open a

large door with ease, and walk in to the surgical suite. They begin with the drawers, opening every single one and pulling out the contents to find what they deem useful.

Although the first notebook is enough for them to web a chair over to them, sit down and put their feet up.

The scorpion is the natural predator of the spider. Spider-Man is untouchable all because of his sixth sense; he could spend his entire life with his eyes closed and still dodge the danger, still fight effectively. However, no other villain has the same power, making Spider-Man an awful opponent to try and keep still. He doesn't know what it is like to fight someone like him, but I plan to give him a run for his money. Gargan is the perfect test subject, and Jameson will pay anything to have someone be capable of getting rid of Spider-Man once and for all. The experiment is a success, and Gargan is showing the instincts of a Scorpion.

Two hours later, it appears Gargan is still changing. I can't say for certain if it is good or not, but had I not tranquilised him, Jameson would be dead. I ran some tests, there's flaws in the experiment. The stronger he gets, the more it affects his mind.

"This is *very* thorough research. A+," they say, clapping. "Although, did you not know what happened to the Lizard, Stillwell?" they fire a web at the door, and it closes shut, another

web locks the door. He has only been standing there a second, in surprise. But nothing gets past Spider-Man. "You and me need to talk. Mac Gargan? You must be proud."

He just stands there, and Spider-Man rolls his eyes behind the mask. "Come on! I figure the experiment isn't going right? So, on that basis, we both want the same thing."

"The experiment went fine."

"Ha! You've not seen him. He's losing his marbles, Stillwell. Do you have an antidote?"

"I do," he eventually replies. "I haven't made it yet."

"Then get on that. He's trouble for me, I'd prefer not to fight him again without the antidote," Spider-Man says as he puts the book back.

"Where are you going?"

"What made you think I was going anywhere? I have one more thing to ask of you: the poison."

"You want an antidote?"

"The side effects."

"It's a prototype of a hallucinogenic neurotoxin, I'm not one hundred percent sure on what it will do, but an extract from an Eclipta Alba plant, which is an --"

"Natural steroid, I know." It seems to take the doctor by surprise, that Spider-Man is well informed about science. Well, Catra did attend a special science-focused high school.

"You'll need an antitoxin as well: atropine."

"Atropine? You've created a pesticide?" Spider-Man almost laughs.

Stillwell frowns, and Spider-Man clears his throat in place of a laugh.

"Yeah, your little experiment has *flaws* , I'll say," he mumbles. "Anyway, Gargan attacked Jameson? He paid for this experiment to defeat me, right? Haha, he's so not gonna like this; I have to protect him."

"It started off by hiring Gargan to find out how Catra takes photos of you. How does she?"

They.

Friends? Roommates? I didn't even know they took pictures of me, it's a bit weird. "They take photos of me?" *Yeah, good save.*

"How didn't you know?"

"I'm busy swinging," they turn away and walk in a circle, but the moment their back is turned, their spidey-sense tingles, and they automatically jump to the ceiling, dodging a bullet. " *Really* ?" they look down. "A tranq gun?" They proceed to dodge four more rounds. "Is this part of your research?" they ask as they shoot a line of webbing at the gun, and zip it over to themself. "Well..." they jump to the floor. "I take it you won't do the antidote? I'm a kind person, you make the antidote, I'll let you in on something."

"You would."

Spider-Man nods. "Only when you show me the antidote."

Stillwell watches the vigilante leave, taking the tranq gun with him. It's a funny story to be able to tell, not many people can say they've had a conversation (or even a deal) made with Spider-Man. It's definitely one to tell... well, maybe not Jameson, but a media outlet who has a more positive reception to the hero.

Three days and no sign of Scorpion. For everyone else, it's a good thing, but not for Spider-Man. Not for Catra either. They can't deal with someone being after both... parts of themself? The hero and civilian?

It's been a troublesome few days for them, no matter what. No matter what they do to distract themself, Spider-Man's responsibility to protect this city is at the forefront of their mind. They throw themself into their job as a mechanic, but it's no use, they constantly think about their other job.

It's becoming a problem, and they have no one to lean on, not really. Adora can never really understand what it’s like. Nor Felicia. Adora was living with Bow now out of Catra’s panic. They miss her, her presence in their apartment, but they won't put her in danger, especially not when Scorpion knows their civilian identity, but hasn't made the connection. It's likely to be made sooner or later with the longer Scorpion hides from the public eye; the longer he isn't in the Raft.

By pure coincidence while they doing their routine patrol, they spot Scorpion coming out of a building, and they drop down, forgetting about his own sixth sense that alerts him to danger.

They dodge his counterattack, firing blasts of webbing at him before delivering a strong roundhouse kick to his torso. It knocks him down, so they see no reason to stop there, and follow through with an axe kick, timed perfectly to knock him down again when he sits up. An attack from his tail forces them to make a gap between them, as they dodge onto the wall of a building near by.

Scorpion is clearly more unhinged than their previous encounter, but they use that to their advantage to use brawn over brains to try and weaken him from the start. He's stronger than before, and that's not what Spider-Man really wanted to witness when he already struggled against him before. He really could crush him like a bug. *The scorpion is the natural predator of the spider.* A statement he is sick of hearing, it's been all over the newspapers and online articles ever since Scorpion defeated Spider-Man. It's made people lose their confidence in the web-slinger.

Scorpion rises, and Spider-Man, holding onto the wall with their right hand and foot, dodges his stinger piercing the wall by turning out of the way, onto their left hand and foot. They quickly gain an idea, and push off the wall and fire two lines of webbing,

and recoil them as their feet slam into his back, a satisfying whack as he is forced against the wall, before performing a back flip put a few metres between them.

A few more dodges and attacks follow, and with each one, Spider-Man swears that they can see as each last strand of sanity are snapped in his mind. They both dodge an on-coming truck, but they also both dodge onto the top of said truck. It's difficult to even move safely, let alone fight at such close proximity. They have to settle for face punches on a 'one given, one received' basis' as they can't dodge without risking dodging to the side of the truck, and have their opponent kick them off into the road, and at such high speeds, neither really want that. Well, Scorpion has armour, so he would be alright, but not Spider-Man in his spandex.

A bridge makes their sixth senses force them to dodge, Scorpion falls to the roof of the truck while Spider-Man jumps and swings over the bridge, and they fire a web at Scorpion to pull him off the truck, and perching on the side of the bridge, they swing him underneath, almost feeling bad when the web is suddenly pulled from their grasp, and they hang upside down to view a newly run over Scorpion, and the car seems to have come off worse than him. It wasn't their intention.

"Sorry!" they shout as they pick up Scorpion with another web and swing away from the scene. In a less busy area, they release the web, and watch as Scorpion falls onto the ground. They go to

drop on top of him, thinking him too weak to dodge as he hasn't moved in a while, but God, were they wrong about that. His tail moves, stinger right into their arm, and they divert their attack and land on the ground, a safe distance away. They definitely felt something enter their system, and stagger around before their legs give in, and they fall backwards. By the time they come back around to their senses, there is no sign of Scorpion, but pain shoots through their body and they instantly use their web shooters to get to higher ground.

They stare down, as at least ten metres from the ground is sea of poison. They swing in a specific direction, barely avoiding the liquid below.

The window is open, so they literally swing into the apartment and collapse on the floor. Felicia stares at them. "Fancy you dropping in," she chuckles to herself before poking them with her freshly painted toes. "Come on, Spider. I know you better than that."

She flinches when they suddenly scream in what can only be described as complete and utter agony, as they jump up and stick to the ceiling.

It's some kind of hallucinogenic toxin that they've been injected with, Catra tells her because they're clearly seeing things, and they don't know if it's real or not, until they ask Felicia if there is a sea of green poison surrounding them, and how can she be sitting in it with no pain. It was like sitting in a swimming pool of boiling water. They tell her about Stillwell's lab, and she is quick to suit up and head to the location to steal the antidote for the poison, but not before coaxing Catra off the ceiling and pulling off their mask and loosening their suit so they can breathe easier.

By the time Black Cat returns, they are much worse than before, and in her minor panic, she stabs the syringe into their upper arm and inject them with the antidote. "There was only one antidote," she says after a few minutes. "It was labelled 'poison anti-dote' so it was the right one, before you freak out, Spider."

"Thank you..." they sigh.

Felicia smiles, and turns on the TV to the news channel. "I hate to say it... but you'll have to leave me now."

"Why?"

Her gloved finger points to the screen, and she reads the headline of the live broadcast. "Scorpion is at the Daily Bugle." She looks back at Spider-Man, but they're gone.

Jonah Jameson's office is at the very top floor of the Daily Bugle building, and Spider-Man wishes it wasn't, as always having roof-top fights gets boring. Although, it takes the focus off of trying to protect civilians. He jumps through the hole in the office wall that Scorpion made, and attaches a web to Jameson and pulls him from the grasp of the enemy. Ordering the man to stay behind him, a trade of attacks follow, using various office supplies. Although there is a moment of ' *I didn't mean to attack you with a pen'* look shared between them when Spider-Man fires web at a pen instead of the desk.

Both Spider-Man and Scorpion stop their battle upon Stillwell's arrival into the office. It gives Jameson time to escape, but Spider-Man knows Scorpion will go after him, so they attack, but he easily throws them by their webbing out of the hole in the wall.

Spider-Man sighs, running up the side of the building when the publisher screams, and they are just in time to catch him as he is

thrown off the roof. They lower him to the ground, where police cars are arriving at the scene, before climbing back to the roof and knocking Scorpion over with a swinging kick. While he is weaker, it has been hour since their last encounter. "I get that you're angry --"

" *But killing him isn't the only way to go!* Would you just *shut up* ?" Scorpion mocks, then wrath takes it's place. He seems to know it well.

"Ha, you know that's very rude to say to someone. Would you like a lesson in manners?" they say as they fire webbing to prevent him from moving, and use the small window of time they have before he undoes it to land some good hits. Scorpion is the losing party when it comes to hand to hand combat skills; most of Spider-Man's villains are. You can be as strong as you want, but if you just rely on brute force alone, it won't get you far against a trained fighter, unless you are Rhino, because then you have about eight feet of height, and tremendous strength.

"I've defeated you twice. You aren't hard work."

"So, you're not wondering why I'm still alive?"

"The poison?"

" *Ding, ding, ding!* " they swing around to attack again, but he blocks. "Stillwell has an antidote for your powers as well."

That comment seems to enrage him further, as while Spider-Man dodges a blast of poison, he's quick to move and pull his opponent to the roof top with such force, they both go through the roof, and then another floor. Inside, Spider-Man has more advantage, more objects to swing or cling to. Scorpion works best in an open area.

Spider-Man runs along the wall, dodging more blasts of poison, and they successfully swing a desk around as their weapon. It splits in half almost too easily, despite the reduced amount of armour protecting Scorpion.

"I don't want it!"

"You want to stay like this?" they ask, genuinely curious, as they back flip out of the way of another desk, and they use their web shooters to swing it back to their opponent; the office now in a complete state of ruin.

He dodges. "Don't be stupid. As if you would want to go back to your normal life."

"Well, ok, valid point. Use your powers for good, then," they suggest.

"I can't."

"Why not?" they say as they prepare their next attack.

"I'll never be able to!" he screams, and pulls Spider-Man off the wall and throws him into the wall, once again *through* it. He continues to shout about how he will never be able to be himself, all because of Jameson. Once more his tail pierces Spider-Man's

arm. What he didn't know, was that the antidote is still in their bloodstream, and they only pretend to lay there and be affected by it as Scorpion heads to the roof. It only really messes with their brain for a few minutes, but in those few minutes, a different fight has taken place, and Scorpion was victorious. Spider-Man was too out of it to register the scream as Stillwell falls from the roof top, as he tried to give the antidote, but Scorpion threw him off the roof. He tried to throw the antidote as he fell, but it missed.

And by the Spider-Man staggers up to the roof, they are too late to save the doctor, but they managed to pull off Scorpion's tail with their webs, and with his major weapon out of the battle, it really is just a melee combat fight that ensues. He's weak, and his motivation is wavering. Spider-Man can only think that he allowed him to win because he stopped fighting back, and the final punch is one to knock him out so the police can safely take him to the Raft.

They head back to their apartment, throw the suit on the floor as soon as they can, and pull on sweatpants and a loose t-shirt, and lay on the sofa as they watch the news coverage of the fight, and that is becoming routine now. They win a fight, they go back home and see what the news reporters are saying about it. This time, they text Adora saying that she can come back now.

Spider-Man saves J. Jonah Jameson's life.

That's all they can say, as if to rub it in his face. Ever since Spider-Man appeared, he has relentlessly hated him. Ever since Spider-Man appeared, he has done nothing but publish negative articles and rumours about him.

News reporters and journalists ask the most important question about this ordeal; will Jameson support Spider-Man after this, or will he continue to ask if Spider-Man is a threat or a menace.

Catra wants to know the answer as bad as the next person, but they have plans that will preoccupy them in the morning. It's a good reason, and part of them can't really believe it.

But, of course, they leapt at the chance to go on a dinner date with Adora.

the vulture

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Before Catra took photos of Spider-Man for the Daily Bugle, they had to find out that they could even earn money from photos in the first place.

And it started with the Vulture, or Adrian Toomes, if you have some degree of respect.

Catra sighs, almost bored out of their mind. The crime rates in New York have plummeted because no one wanted to carry a crime out when they knew Spider-Man would just jump in and stop them before it even started. There was a sudden spike when overconfident thugs thought they could give Spider-Man a good game, but they were so wrong. Part of Catra wants to go and see the Green Goblin just to see him get enraged at the sight of Spider-Man.

When there's hardly any crime, or crime that just requires a press of web shooters while they swing by, they become bored. There's not been any proper villain for a while either. That isn't much of a complaint, as it's nice to not worry about getting killed for once. They've even been hanging out with Adora due to having more

time to themself. They didn't want to jinx anything; it's still early days after all, no matter how high their hopes have gotten.

Adora gets annoyed with Catra because they are constantly checking their phone for live news feed of any crimes, and they haven't told her the other reason for checking their phone; that Black Cat has agreed to be an alternative source of any on going crimes, that aren't her own. They haven't told Adora about Felicia, not personally anyway. They see no reason to as it would just complicate things even more, as there would be no secret in knowing they preferred her because she was like them in the sense she wears a costume and swings above New York. Of course, the media has countless articles about the two of them, there's no stopping them, or stopping Adora from reading them. They assume Adora doesn't want to know -- or ask about it. Perhaps the answer is obvious, especially without bringing the topic up. They still work with Felicia, she has saved their life countless times, and they will always be there for her. It's like hanging out with your ex, except you spend half the time being recorded for the news while fighting some new villain, so there is proof they are just trying to save the city, and while doing that, there is little time for anything else.

Yet, there is more than enough time to think back on the memories. Catra doesn't know how to feel about that.

"How does it work?" she asked out of the blue as they lay in bed, and they knew exactly what she was referring to. She lays on her side, and the thin bed sheet is tucked under her right arm, taught

against the rest of her body. Catra has to force themself to stop looking at her perfect hourglass figure. Her hand moves to their bicep as her long silver hair falls over her bare shoulder.

"It's complicated..."

"Like us?" She steals the words from their mouth.

"Like we always finish each other's sentences?" they chuckle before kissing her. "It's just a cheat, really," they say, going back to her original question. "It's great for me, not for my opponents, and it's automatic. It forces my body to move before I even know it's moved."

"When?" she inquires, almost too curious. Too much of which would be bad for a cat.

"When something is a threat to me."

"What if I punch you now?"

"That would be rude," they joke.

"Would you block it?"

"Do you think I see you as a threat?"

She's slow to answer that, as she really thinks about it, yet she suddenly goes to punch them, and they catch her fist in their palm.

"Sorry, I wasn't expecting that. It happens when I have my guard down, like right now, and you're a trained fighter." A thought that springs to mind is: 'not like if Adora punched me.'

Felicia looks at them, as she thinks of an idea. She's quick to move and straddle them. "It didn't go off then," she states.

"Well, I'm not sure this is how fights tend to work," they say, trying to maintain eye contact, yet their will power is weak, and their eyes wander.

"Where are your web shooters?"

Catra looks at her, reaching their arm down off the side of the bed. There's a small clicking sound, and then the familiar sound of webbing being released. "I don't know why I bother taking them off," they muse before sliding their legs out from under Felicia and pushing her onto her back. Her smirk almost makes them melt, but there's something about how her restrained hands wriggle above her head (that is completely her idea), that is almost comforting, in that they can be completely themself, both parts, without concern, not even over her safety.

They will always be there for Felicia because of their past together, and dare they say that they miss her. It didn't matter that their relationship didn't work out as it was both of their faults; she obviously preferred Spider-Man, and they did judge her for her criminal background. Yet, fighting villains, they made -- make -- a good team. They work well in combat, not so much personally when their relationship was unhealthy, yet they both took some time to realise that fact. Of course, the media didn't make it seem that way, and they made it seem like they were on track to get married and spend the rest of their lives together as soulmates, when it was anything but that. Well, maybe it could had been, but that was all it was, a *'could have been'* . While Felicia still flirts with them (they are sure it is part of her

personality by now), they don't react. They can't -- not when their relationship with Adora is improving, and they will always have undeniable feelings for her. They just have to make sure that the two never cross paths, although it's difficult when Felicia can easily find out who Catra knows.

Adora has all the reason to be annoyed with Catra, but she also knows that Catra will always have to protect the city whenever it needs Spider-Man. They are sure that anyone could wear the mask, it just happens to be them. And that they can never get a blood test again, not unless the doctor knows, and will conduct the test himself, or better yet, just let Spider-Man waltz into the hospital and do his own blood test because it can't be that hard. Plus, they really want to compare their blood to a normal person's blood sample.

Opening the door to their apartment, they pick up the newspaper that has been thrown at it (probably from the end of the corridor), and they close it again. They only get the newspaper delivered so they don't forget to read it to see what J. Jonah Jameson has to say about Spider-Man. Probably nothing positive. A page catches their eye, an advert of a cash reward for a picture of the Vulture, and their stomach drops when they think they've somehow missed the latest villain. They're about to text Felicia, but they search the web, realising that the Vulture has been on a spree of robbery, so their plans for tonight are sorted out.

But it means they have to cancel on Adora.

Spider-Man perches on the edge of roof top to have a good view of the building opposite; one that the Vulture had stolen from last night or rather, early morning. The point was that Spider-Man was now here to stop him. Sometimes, he did miss out due to sleeping, which he doesn't get much of, so he sleeps for a long time when he gets the chance. It's not all super powered villains or human mutates like him that he has to deal with; Wilson Fisk is a particularly troublesome foe for him, and the less said about him, the better.

It doesn't take long for the Vulture to fly along, and that's when they strike with their web-shooters, and pull him to a stop by webbing his mechanical wings. "Don't get your feathers in a flap," they weren't too proud of that quip, but they couldn't think of anything else just yet. They hold the two webs in one hand, a separate one in their other stuck to a nearby building, allowing them to swing overhead to snap a picture of him. "Smile!" They're smug, probably too much, as it didn't spring to their mind what happened next: that in their moment of distraction, Vulture saw the opportunity to start flying, and bring Spider-Man with him. "How nice of you to give me a lift," they call out as they put their phone away and let go of one of the webs to make him top heavy. They fire a web to a building to steady themself, and they jump onto a wall as they watch the Vulture barely gain his balance back, moments before he would have hit the road below. They swing after him, and they realise they need to come up with a gadget to clip his wings. A net gun, perhaps? They can't say for certain how quickly they could make one. The web shooters were hard enough, but if they could craft some sort of device that will fire a net made of their webbing, it might just work.

With web in one hand and phone in the other, they attempt to take some more photos of the Vulture, just without webs on his wings this time. They say you shouldn't use your phone while driving, and this applies to swinging, as with the distraction of firing a web to catch their phone before it hits the ground, the Vulture strikes them out cold.

They wake up in some kind of tank filled with water. It's cylindrical, wide, and they can't see a fucking thing. The water is ice cold (the reason why they wake up as soon as they were submerged), and they try to climb the walls but they just fall back into the water below. When their spidey-sense tingles, they can't possibly see how this can get any worse, until the water level suddenly rises. "What's your plan?" they yell, trying to keep their head above the surface, along with their hands as they've not tested if their web shooters are water proof, and they don't want a practical test. They can sense he is somewhere outside.

"Why would I tell you?" the Vulture answers, and they can vaguely hear him fly away.

"I guess he's right, but I don't what he was thinking either," they mutter as they fire two lines of webbing to the top of the tank and pull down on them before letting go to slingshot upwards. They punch through the top of tank and jump out. They have no idea what he's planning or where he's gone, so they end up going home to get out of their soaked costume.

They take out their phone and text Felicia after putting on clean clothes, who informs them about the Park Avenue Jewellery Exchange, and says that the Vulture will probably steal the diamonds. Catra texts back: *'I thought you would be after them.'*

It's worth checking it out, though. Felicia is normally right about these types of things, seeing as it is her field of expertise. She answers fairly quickly, saying that they are too quick to assume such things, and another text follows up with: *'I'll steal them right under the Vulture's beak. Do you need help taking him down?'*

'Sure, I need someone to distract him, and you're good at that.'

'What? Because you always get distracted when you see me?'

'Just be on time.'

'Ha, that's the thing about me. I'm never late, unlike you.'

'Well, they do say not to stop at what you're good at.'

'That's why I went back to burglary.'

'You could use your skills for good.'

'Do you still like me, Catra?

I'm using my talent for good, robbing the rich and giving to the poor

I'll take your ignorance as a 'yes' then?'

Catra sighs as they throw their phone on the bed and print out their photos of the Vulture to take to the Daily Bugle in the morning. Felicia says she will move if it will make it easier for them, as they run into each other quite a bit. They're not sure. While it would make things easier with Adora, they would miss not having Felicia's back up. They need to focus on something else entirely, so they start fiddling around with the net gun they purchased to modify it into a Spider-Man weapon.

"You wouldn't be able to get pictures of Spider-Man, would you?"

"Ah, you'd be surprised," they smile a little.

"Do you know who he is then?"

"It's a secret identity for a reason, sir."

Catra leaves the office with a new job as a freelance photographer for the Daily Bugle, taking photos of Spider-Man... for Jameson to portray him in a negative light. They head home and change into Spider-Man, and meet Black Cat on their usual roof top.

"Are you going to answer my question?"

"What question?" they play dumb even if they know she will see right through it.

"Actually, it's ok. Nevermind," she points her index finger to the right.

"Are you stealing bird food? I didn't think Vultures eat seed," Spider-Man fires a web at the Vulture and pulls him towards the roof top.

"This one will be eating spider soon enough."

"So will this cat," Black Cat mutters under her breath, and Spider-Man pauses and looks down at her. She knows the look they are giving her, even under the mask.

"Are you annoyed that the bird seed wasn't up to scratch?" they ask before kicking him.

"You're a poor excuse for a spider; four limbs."

"Hey, you watch your beak with that jealousy," they begin swinging once he starts flying, and manage to pull him to the ground after Black Cat throws a smoke bomb. "I've never seen a green vulture before, did you eat a rotten corpse?"

Felicia rolls her eyes, "Did you stay up all night thinking of these?"

"Oh, I get it now! You're called the Vulture because you have a bald head!" they shout from the top of the lamp post.

She sniggers. "Ok, you can have that one. It's true, at least."

All three of them move through the city towards the truck transporting the jewels, police cars behind and in front of it.

Felicia jumps on top of the truck carrying the diamonds, and the Vulture takes off in her direction. Spider-Man fires the web net, and down the Vulture goes. Spider-Man pretends to be preoccupied with knocking the Vulture unconscious to notice Black Cat entering the truck, taking the diamonds and then escaping, but when the police pull their guns out, they have no choice but to go after Felicia, not to stop her, but protect her.

The Raft is relatively new, and no one is sure how to handle these super powered villains, especially if they are so strong without their suits (apart from Rhino, who has managed to break out twice, and Spider-Man and Black Cat put him back behind bars). Word has it that Scorpion is going even more insane in solitary confinement, the Green Goblin as well. The Lizard isn't viewed as a threat, and they are thinking of moving him to Ryker's. No one has managed to come up with specialised restraints to make the super humans behave as regular humans yet, so Scorpion can still climb walls and Rhino could probably destroy the entire prison if

he really wanted to. It's just a matter of time until the criminals plan their escape, and if all of them escape, there's only one Spider-Man, and he can't be in five places at once. If they don't have their suits, well, Spider-Man probably wouldn't recognise them, much like themself out of the iconic red and blue suit.

Although Catra's new job was thanks to the Vulture, they have to give him credit for helping them with something as well.

It was similar, but Adora soon got the hang of it. While Catra used to web up their camera to a wall and swing past as Spider-Man, sometimes the camera would be left there because of a crime that needed stopping, sometimes stolen while they were away, or the photos were blurred. The other method was to throw the camera, set again on a timer, and pose, and fire a web to bring it back to safety.

However, with Adora standing on a rooftop, she’s able to get a wide range of shots as Spider-Man swings past, including photos of him stopping crime if the timing was right.

Adora is still terrified of swinging above fast traffic, clinging to Catra as if her life depends on it. She knew she didn’t have to be scared, but that one time Catra let go of her and then caught her had scarred her for life. Catra often brings it up just to get a reaction, usually resulting in Adora leading Catra to their bed to teach her a lesson.

“Hey, Otto,” Catra greets as they walk into the garage where they work as his lab assistant. The mechanic job was now a cover up. The business was closed after Otto had earned enough money for his science experiments. He was like a father to them, and they wanted nothing more than to help him with his latest invention. Having worked with them since they were a teenager, being 23 now, it hurt them to see his health decline. They had even come up with some more ideas to help with the invention themself, including some secret plans for a new Spider-Man suit.

Chapter End Notes

> the final chapter will be out in a few weeks, as i have started college again and its not fully finished yet

part three: the hero

Chapter Notes

> This is the final draft of the chapter uploaded by a friend. All I know is that Blake intentionally made the fights short as most villains had their own dedicated chapter, and it would be repetitive. As it's a draft (that I have proofread), I do not know what the finalised version of the chapter would be, but I hope you enjoy!

It's four in the morning by the time Catra gets home from a night of patrolling, tugging off the mask and throwing it somewhere as they collapse onto their bed where a sleeping Adora lays. The suit is badly damaged from fighting three of their worst enemies one after the other as the Raft still don't quite know how to handle super powered people. It's a theme now; they defeat them, they break out of prison, they defeat them, they hate Spider-Man even more (if that's even possible for some). Scorpion always tries to head to the Daily Bugle to get revenge, while the others just target Spider-Man. Scorpion doesn't make it far with his damaged suit. Rhino is obviously the hardest one for the prison staff to control since his suit can't be taken off, and he needs his own special room - extra large. Another thing is that the staff have banned Spider-Man from dropping by and provoking the prisoners. He wouldn't call it that; he was just complimenting Scorpion on his scratched portrait of Spider-Man on the wall, and Rhino on his very violent poem of what he will do to Spider-Man upon his release from the Raft.

There's a bright light from the distance, followed by a loud explosion of something, and they groan, finding their mask and climbing out the window. There's a decent sized crater with a meteorite, and they swing into the crater to check it out. There's something like black goo on the meteorite, and they slowly poke it

with a finger to determine the viscosity, but the moment they do, the material rushes from the rock up their forearm, slowly expanding to cover their body, copying the design of their suit as it settles down. They're not too sure how to feel about a black and white suit, but that soon changes when they go to shoot a line of webbing, and instead of the web shooter reacting, the same black material reacts and creates a web from whatever it's made of. Instead of going to bed, they decide to spend time testing their new abilities on any petty criminals, who definitely won't be able to see them coming if they blend into the night.

About an hour into their patrol, they land on a roof top when they catch sight of a familiar figure.

"New suit?" she asks. "I like the red and blue better, Spider."

"I thought you would say that, Felicia."

"Because you know me so well," she steps closer, but she knows better than to push her luck. "How's Adora?"

"Good," they answer. "It's almost a record this time that I've not freaked out and broken up."

"I know."

"So, uh, are you back for long?"

"That's a weird question to ask your ex, Spider," she teases with that damn smirk of hers. "No, I was just passing through," she says as she walks towards the edge of the roof. "I'll see you around, yeah?"

Catra smiles a little before heading in the opposite direction, aiming to go back home and try and sleep after dealing with any more crimes they happen to see on their way. It's half six by the time they climb through the window, and Adora is already gone as she has the early morning shift at her job. They collapse into bed and fall asleep after removing the black suit, or rather, asking it to remove itself. It's something they might be able to get used to, it's increased their abilities even more. Although, new photos of Spider-Man's new suit were being paid for generously by J. Jonah Jameson, it was angering a certain someone even more.

It's a week later, and Catra believes they have some thing of a sleep schedule now, but they feel exhausted all the time. That,

and the suit is acting on it's own. Usually, it's controlled by thoughts, but their control over it is slipping, and fast. The sleep deprivation is harming them, and it's something that the symbiote realises, and they make up their mind to stop controlling their host's body while they sleep.

They can only think of one person who might be able to help them with this, so they swing by his lab and let themself in. "Dr Octavius?" they call out.

"Spider-Man?"

"Uh, Catra said you might be able to help me."

"Oh, of course! I often forget they are friends with you," he says as he stops working on whatever it was he was working on. They didn't glance or anything, as they feel it's not their business. Not as Spider-Man, anyway.

"It's about this suit. I think it's alive."

Half an hour of various tests, which ends with Spider-Man finally managing to remove the black suit like before, and the scientist concludes that the suit is not just alive, but sentient, and it wants to permanently bond with Spider-Man.

"How can I stop this?"

"As we found out, one of it's weaknesses is fire."

"So, we start a fire?"

"Precisely."

The symbiote squirms, and Spider-Man shudders at the feeling. It's clearly growing uncomfortable and angry with the rejection as a bonfire is lit outside. Spider-Man looks at Dr Octavius, who nods, so they begin to walk towards the flames, stopping when the symbiote reacts by beginning to reveal the red and blue suit as it recoils away from the flames. The scientist approaches and funnels the symbiote into a container, screwing on the lid.

After thanking the doctor for his help, they leave.

After Spider-Man leaves, Otto can't help but study the creature even more, discovering that it has imprinted Spider-Man's abilities onto itself. They lock it away and lock up the lab for the day, but that's the only opening a recently free prisoner needs to take the container and offer it a new host.

Mac has to give credit to Aleksei for causing a distraction as he headed to retrieve his suit, and he made a deal with the rest of the villains there that he would be the one to defeat Spider Man, but also finish his own vendetta against Jameson for good now that he has this trick up his sleeve.

The streets of New York are ablaze, sirens wailing, prisoners of the Raft running, and Spider-Man swinging above their heads, webbing them to walls as he tries to get to the prison.

Last week, if you told Catra the city would be in ruins, Spider-Man’s biggest enemies escaped and teamed up, they would have laughed, saying that was impossible.

Scorpion is the first old foe he meets, dodging a blast of poison turns him into the path of a black tendril of Venom. Their fight must be a trap, Mac must be leading Spider-Man to a certain

place. Out of all of them, Scorpion is his favourite enemy. He tells him as such, shouting up at him as he drags him along the tarmac at quite a speed, before suddenly a strong coil clamp - replacing Venom's vice like grip - around him, and no sooner did he register the pain did he get yanked so fast into the air that he felt his stomach get left behind. Looking up, Spider-Man sees the Vulture, and looking down, he sees Scorpion jumping from rooftop to rooftop after them. Something small and sharp severs the connection between the Vulture and Spider-Man, and he begins to fall, still restrained. He is aware of something green approaching him at speed, hoisting him up - the Green Goblin on his glider.

Maybe a couple of minutes pass before thunderous footsteps can be heard, and the Green Goblin drops his opponent with no regard to his well being, and he lands on top of Rhino. The impact of the coil on his armour breaks it. Spider-Man is free. He fires a web at the Vulture, pulling him hard and fast to hit the tarmac so hard it cracks. He fires two webs at the Scorpion, slingshotting himself towards him, his feet into his abdomen. The road cracks again, and Spider-Man is quick to web Mac to it. Yet Venom had other plans.

Spider-Man knew what to do for Venom. Petrol leaking from an upturned car just needed a little boost. And he just happens to be near a convenience store. He dives in through a smashed window, swinging along the aisles until he finds a box of matches. He strikes several, throwing them into the flammable substance, before swinging up and away to tackle into the Green Goblin, sending him to the road below as he barrels into him, knocking him off his glider.

Next up is Rhino, he slingshots at him, webs propelling him and all his strength into the back of him, muscles aching at how hard the impact was, especially since he was greeted by his armour. But he is done.

All of them are. For now.

The spidey-sense forces him to dodge a large tail. He turns to see the Lizard, wasting no time in engaging in combat. Someone must've given him the serum again unless his DNA and mind had been permanently damaged from their last fight a few years ago. No doubt this is a trap, he will probably be captured by another villain, but who? There isn't anyone who comes to mind. They continue to a specific location, abandoned and deathly still. And then he hears a mechanical whirring, and he is seized in the midst of a web swing to dodge an attack from the Lizard. He hasn't seen this one before. Four mechanical arms obeying the man they belong to. Eight limbs in total if you count his human ones. Well, he's more of a spider than Spider-Man if one wanted to be accurate. But he recognised the voice and face of that man.

Dr Otto Octavius.

And he declares himself the leader of the Sinister Six. Out of the shadows emerge the remaining five.

Coming closer and closer. Spider-Man takes another step back, rubble falls into the water below. It occurs to him, they're on the Williamsburg bridge. It has been blocked off by overturned cars at both ends.

Catra tries to remain calm, thankful for the mask hiding their shock and conflicted feelings. They warned him that the neural interface that controls the prosthetics limbs may harm his mind. He ignored them.

Trying to ignore the fear making them light headed, they jump into the action, but six against one is heartless. No, just five. They note that Otto isn't moving, he just orders. The Lizard and Scorpion lunge for Spider-Man, he jumps up, dodging. The Vulture hoists him further, but he webs his face and pushes off. "Sorry, no time to talk!" they quip, taking advantage of his confusion.

He drops down, dances around Scorpion and the Green Goblin, making easy work of them. Rhino seizes him, slamming him into the road below. Something cracks, not just the road surface. They use both hands to block a powerful punch from both Scorpion and the Lizard as Rhino's fist collides with their sternum, feeling the impact along both arms and all over their torso.

In the mask, the electronic display alerts him to a text from Adora. They ignore, rolling onto their stomach, heaving air into their lungs. Trembling, they manage to get on their hands and knees. Then a foot slams into their back, squashing them like a bug, their limbs given in. Something thin pierces their left bicep, but they barely register it as at the same time, one of them grabs their head and slams it back into the ground. They can only hope that it wasn't Scorpion.

But it was. They fire a web at a pillar and attempt to swing out of the way to safety, but the Lizard's claws sever it and they crash back to the road, vision blurry. They crawl as the five kick him.

A mechanical claw grabs his leg, pulling him up to the face of Dr Octavius. "Your first and final warning: stay out of our way," he orders, tossing them off the bridge.

In a rescue boat, Adora alerts the police officer to the car where Spider-Man lays, partly through the sunroof, otherwise just splayed across the length of the vehicle, unconscious and bleeding.

Catra shoots up, sore and bruised, but awake in some warehouse. Bow's worry confirms to them that they didn't just have a dream where his greatest enemies broke out of the Raft, led by their boss.

"Where's Adora?" they croak.

"She was the one who found you… she didn't come back," Bow hesitates in telling them that. Catra completely forgets that Bow probably wasn't aware who was behind Spider-Man's mask. And Catra has a feeling that Otto knows as well. They scramble, finding their suit, pulling it on over the bandages and bruises. One time, they were in the garage, trying to fix their suit with Otto's tools, needing the specific tools for the electronics. Otto walked in, and their panic boiled over. He knew. No one who is that smart wouldn't put the two together, yet he said it was obvious.

That Catra was Spider-Man's suit maker. They were smart and had a way with mechanics. They were Spider-Man's friend.

They weren't as relieved as they should have been.

With six years of being Spider-Man, not just the suit had upgraded tech. So did Spider-Bot. It was connected via Bluetooth to the heads-up display fitted in the eyes of Spider-Man's mask. A

camera feed, if selected, could allow Catra to see what it sees. It was useful for snooping about, such as tracking down the lair of the Sinister Six.

Catra sets Spider-Bot on a course for the Otto's car garage turned lab while they went on patrol. They believe they have defeated Venom for good, or that he found another host, feeling that Mac wasn't up to the task. If that's the case, they will deal with that at a later date. feeling that Venom wouldn't seek out Spider-Man when adjusting to a new host. Well, it's more of a hope than them being certain.

While on patrol, they ambush Scorpion and Rhino in a shipyard. They try to avoid receiving harsh impacts, but dodging causes the snapped ends of their broken bones to scrape against each other, like fingernails on a chalkboard, they shudder at the sensation. Heavy hits to the two villains, the fight turns between them as Rhino rages at Scorpion, and Spider-Man takes the opportunity to pull open an empty container just as Rhino charges his teammate inside, and Spider-Man webs it shut.

Cracking their back, they stretch out their limbs and joints before moving off to wait out their next opponent. With information from Spider-Bot, they head to the location provided to meet the Lizard and the Vulture.

A battle in the sky commences between the two, the Lizard helpless on the ground below. Spider-Man wraps the Vulture up in

a mass of webbing, effortlessly slinging the mass off to the side, catching on a nearby lamp post as he drops down, landing with one knee meeting the ground, his foot landing simultaneously, cracking the tarmac. The Lizard snarls and lunges, Spider-Man dodges reflexively in a backflip, slipping an urgent line of webbing from one hand to the other as he lands on the back of his opponent, harsh webbing locking around his throat to try and end this quickly. He pulls back sharply and holds. He deduces that years of confinement has weakened most of his opponents, even with their upgraded suits, but he suspects jail time as been the roughest on the Lizard. They return to brute force upon realising that they would need all the time they could get, eventually knocking the Lizard out and wrapping him in webbing.

As Spider-Man fights, Spider-Bot has been scuttling around the hideout, pinging information of the next opponents' location. After a quick costume change to an armoured Spider suit made from the same material from Doc Ock's arms, prepared a few weeks ago just in case something happened, they are ready.

Running up Oscorp tower, their sprint is intercepted by a green smoke bomb. Their spider-sense forces them to dodge from the building into the air, into the path of the Green Goblin, who speeds into them on his glider, winding them.

Catching their breath, they kick out of the goblin's grip, no doubt there was no Will left, not after years and years of solitary confinement, and the Goblin's vise-like grip on Will's mind. But they have danced this dance plenty of times before, defeating him would be no bother. Not when they are so close to Adora, and her

life depends on how quickly Catra can get to Doc Ock. They take the fight to the roof of the tower, where they see Otto and Adora being held hostage in one of the prosthetic limbs. In rage, they slingshot down with webs on the available high pillars and kick the Goblin's abdomen down to the rooftop, hearing the crack of his armour upon impact. They swing to Doc Ock next.

The Green Goblin lays still, defeated and unconscious. After wrapping him up in webbing, Catra lowers him off the building on a single line of web fluid, taking time to recuperate their wounds while Doc Ock is momentarily stunned and captured in his own bundle of webs.

They lunge at each other.

Tangled in their own limbs, pinned by Doc Ock's, they can only watch as the fourth hoists Adora up. Their eyes bulge as they begin to fight, but the claws dig in so tight they draw blood, likely to sever their wrists and ankles if they continue.

All they can do is watch as Adora is thrown, both of them screaming; Adora's out of pure fear, Catra's out of a mix of rage and grief. They manage to fire a web, it disappears down the side of the building, but there's no sudden weight attached to it. Catra deflates. There was no way she would survive that fall. They still had so much to live for, so much to do and experience together. Even with their ups and downs, they were doing so well for the

last few years. Hell, they were even talking about getting married. It couldn't end here. Not now. Not when Catra repeatedly told Adora they couldn't be together because of this exact scenario, but the lull of her affection was too strong. They should have been firm. No matter how much it hurt them both. They should have let her go.

"What a shame, Catra," Otto's voice cracks through the air, yet it travels through more than just the air, as Catra's heart takes the hit just as badly.

Adora's fall is harshly met by a figure in black swinging and wrapping an arm securely around her waist, using the momentum from Adora to lengthen the swing.

"Watch your step, blondie," a velvety voice prompts as her saviour lands on the rooftop of a nearby building.

In the heads up display of Spider-Man's mask, a notification from Felicia pops up; *She's safe. Take him down.*

Otto flings Spider-Man up in the air, but they fire webs at him, tearing two of his mechanical arms off in their blind rage. They would end this now or not at all. They're running off of adrenaline alone, but they can feel the pain of their broken bones and fresh bruises forming. Doc Ock seizes him, claws disabling his web shooters, in Spider-Man's history of battles, it wasn't an original idea, and they could always defeat an opponent without, it just took a little longer and a little planning. But perhaps they are even now, and they result to hand-to-hand combat on the side of Oscorp tower. Adora may be safe, but Otto knew they were Spider-Man, he was in control all along. He planned to break out some of their worst enemies from the Raft, to destroy Spider-Man.

Even when he knew how much Catra adored him. He was like a father to them.

And they were so naive.

Of course he never believed that Catra made Spider-Man's suit and gadgets. He was too clever to believe such a farce.

A strong right hook connects with Otto's jaw, a crack heard as the impact vibrates up their arm. Their spider-sense forces them to move out of the way of a mechanical arm, and they know that without it, they would be too tired to dodge, or the way they can barely focus their vision due to their tears. They crawl behind him, jump on his back to disconnect the neural interface. His extra

arms power down, and Catra relaxes before leaving to see Adora; Black Cat nowhere to be found.

Adora rolls up their mask to crush her lips against theirs. “I love you,” she tells them, breathless. “I love you so much.”

“I love you too,” Catra smiles before taking off their web shooters in place of the new ones that Spider-Bot has just arrived with. Adora picks the robot up as Catra picks her up to swing back to their apartment and finally get some well deserved rest.

“Eddie Brock,” Catra muses as they sit on the sofa a few weeks later, the news on the TV merely background noise as Adora fills them in on her latest findings from her snooping around. “I recognise that name.”

“Well, the rumours say that he is the new host for Venom. He also worked for the Daily Bugle as a photographer after you left.”

Within seconds, Catra shrugs off their clothes, pulling on gloves and mask. In the light of the setting sun, Adora never tires of

watching such a ritual, nor from the gleam of gold of their ring finger, matching her own.

She catches their attention before they're about to jump out the window. “Go get ‘em, tiger.”

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